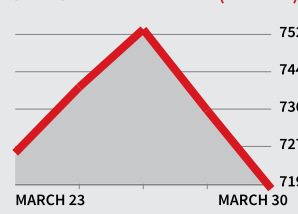


SENSEX 71947.55 (-748.84)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	22331.40	-181.25
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	19.78	-0.20
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.83	+0.86
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	146145.00	+7135
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	230135.00	+10875

NET EXODUS.

For every \$1 that flowed into

physically-backed gold ETFs in March, \$2.34 flowed out, says World Gold Council **p10**

POLLSCAPE.

Shifting rivalries and new entrants sharpen high-profile contests across Tamil Nadu **p7**

QUICKLY.

AVIATION VETERAN

William Walsh named Chief Executive of IndiGo



New Delhi: InterGlobe Aviation (IndiGo) has named aviation veteran William Walsh as Chief Executive Officer (CEO), subject to regulatory approvals. The appointment, announced on Tuesday, brings in a seasoned industry leader as the airline navigates its next phase of expansion. Walsh, who is currently Director-General of the International Air Transport Association, will step down on July 31, 2026, and is expected to take charge by August 3. **p12**

SEMAGLUTIDE GENERICS

Novo Nordisk cuts prices of Ozempic, Wegovy

Mumbai: Danish healthcare major Novo Nordisk for a second time slashed prices in India for its blockbuster obesity drug Wegovy and also its diabetes product Ozempic. This comes a little over a week after a semaglutide patent expired in markets including India, and a slew of cheaper generics was launched. **p12**

RBI defers capital market exposure norms to July 1

UPDATED FRAMEWORK. Clarifies stance on acquisition funding, lending to market participants

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India has deferred the implementation of its revised capital market exposure norms by three months to July 1, while giving key clarifications to address industry concerns around acquisition financing and lending to market participants.

The amended directions, originally scheduled to come into force from April 1, were aimed at enabling bank funding for corporate acquisitions, rationalising loans against financial assets and shifting towards a more principle-based framework for exposure to capital market intermediaries (CMIIs).

However, the RBI said it received representations from banks and industry bodies highlighting operational and interpretational challenges, prompting the extension.

ACQUISITION FINANCE Among the most significant changes are those related to acquisition finance. The RBI



KEY CHANGES. The amended directions were aimed at enabling bank funding for corporate acquisitions and rationalising loans against financial assets **REUTERS**

has expanded the definition to include mergers and amalgamations, while tightening the framework by allowing such financing only for acquisitions that result in control over non-financial target companies. In cases where the target is a holding company, lenders must ensure that "potential synergy" conditions are met at a group level.

In another significant clarification, the central bank said banks can now fund proprietary trading activities of CMIIs, provided the exposure is fully backed by cash or cash equivalents. It also removed the earlier prohibition on financing market makers

against the same securities in which they operate.

"This is a confidence boosting measure. This could lead to better volumes in the market in the coming days," said independent market analyst Arun Kejriwal, adding that this will give a breather to prop trading desks already under stress due to market volatility.

The revised norms also permit acquisition finance to be routed through subsidiaries — domestic or overseas — of the acquiring entity, providing greater structuring flexibility for corporate deals. At the same time, safeguards have been strengthened, refinancing of

acquisition loans will be allowed only after completion of the transaction and establishment of control and must be used solely to retire the original debt. Additionally, banks must obtain corporate guarantees where loans are extended to special purpose vehicles or subsidiaries.

Vijay Mulbagal, Group Executive, Axis Bank, observed that, in general, funding of M&As by banks is treated as a capital market exposure as they are funding equity shares.

Mulbagal said that foreign banks have been doing M&A financing for a long time. Now, for domestic players, there is another alternative in rupee financing.

CAPS ON LOANS

In the retail segment, the RBI clarified that caps on loans against shares and other eligible securities — ₹1 crore per individual — and limits for IPO, FPO and ESOP subscriptions — ₹25 lakh — will apply at the banking system level rather than per lender, a move aimed at preventing regulatory arbitrage.

IT sector faces modest Q4 despite healthy deal pipelines

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

India's IT sector is set for a steady but modest Q4FY26, with analysts pointing to selective demand, elongated decision cycles and weak discretionary spending offsetting healthy deal pipelines and early AI-led opportunities. Mid-single-digit expansion reflects a steady recovery.

Harshal Dasani, Business Head at INVasset PMS, said that in Q4, demand appears stable but not broad-based. However, large deal pipelines remain healthy, led by cost optimisation, vendor consolidation and cloud transformation, while early traction in AI-led projects is beginning to add a new layer of opportunity.

NO BREAKOUT

"Q4 translates into a quarter of measured execution rather than a breakout. Discretionary spending is returning, but unevenly, and decision cycles are elongated, particularly in BFSI and retail verticals. Sequential growth is likely to stay modest, with revenues supported more by deal ramp-ups than fresh spending. Margins could stabilise on lower attrition and controlled costs,

ANALYSTS' TAKE

- Tier-1 firms have indicated strong deal bookings
- However, enterprise spending remains selective
- Sequential growth is likely to stay modest
- Early AI-led opportunities supporting modest growth



though pricing pressure and transition costs may cap upside," he said.

STRONG DEAL BOOKING

Tier-1 companies have indicated strong deal bookings in recent quarters, suggesting an intact underlying demand even if revenue conversion is gradual. A BNP Paribas report noted that deal signings reached a five-month high of 14 in February up from 12 in January, after steadily declining from 18 in September to 10 in December 2025.

Tushar Badjate, Director of Badjate Stock Shares, explained that the IT sector closed Q4 in a moderated demand environment, particularly across key global markets that contribute 70 per cent of export demand.

However, enterprise spending remained selective, with budgets largely directed towards maintenance, cloud migration and AI-led efficiency initiatives, while

largescale transformation programmes continued to be deferred or re-scoped.

Large-caps delivered flat to low single-digit sequential growth, with margins holding in the range of -18-25 per cent, supported by disciplined cost management and improved utilisation. Mid-tier firms, benefiting from niche capabilities and AI integration, relatively outperformed with stronger growth momentum.

Pareek Jain, Founder and CEO of EIR Trend, said the current quarter is expected to be stronger than the last, with optimism supported by Accenture's results, steady BFSI demand, improving geographies and accelerating AI momentum. However, he flagged rising concerns for FY27 as the Gulf conflict drives up oil prices and triggers second-order impact across sectors, potentially delaying tech spending and AI investments.

Switch Mobility races past Tata Motors, Olectra to top FY26 electric bus market

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

For the first time since it entered the electric mobility space in 2022, the Hinduja Group-backed Switch Mobility became India's No 1 electric bus maker in FY26, dethroning Tata Motors and Olectra Greentech with a blistering 177 per cent surge in volumes, far outpacing the overall market's 44 per cent growth, Vahan data showed.

Switch Mobility clocked 1,144 units in FY26, up from 413 a year earlier, taking its market share to 26.4 per cent, driven by strong uptake in large State transport undertaking (STU) tenders.

Switch Mobility edged past PMI Electro Mobility (25.6 per cent) and JBM Auto (24.2 per cent), while former leaders Tata Motors and



Olectra ceded ground.

SETBACK FOR TATA

Tata Motors volumes plunged 83 per cent to 178 units from 1,058 in 2025, with market share collapsing from 35.1 per cent to 4.1 per cent. "The drop comes amid a strategic pivot towards financial prudence and focus on an asset-light business model, with the company instead focusing on non-CESL tenders," said an analyst tracking the sector.

Other incumbents, such as Volvo Eicher Commercial

Vehicles, lagged at just 42 units, signalling the growing mismatch between traditional OEM models and the evolving structure of e-bus tenders.

SERVICE, THE KEY

Industry observers said that success is increasingly tied not to manufacturing scale but to the ability to execute integrated, service-led contracts covering fleet operations, depot management, financing and lifecycle maintenance, areas where new-age players have moved faster.

PMI Electro Mobility scaled to 1,113 buses (up 131 per cent), while JBM Auto grew nearly 198 per cent to 1,052 units. Their rise reflects a structural pivot towards bundled offerings, particularly in tier-2 and -3 markets.

Emerging players are also entering the fray. EKA Mobility deployed 164 buses during the year and is building a pipeline through operator partnerships, signalling further competitive intensity ahead.

"We are seeing a clear shift from pilot projects to large-scale deployments, supported by initiatives like PM e-Bus Sewa," said Sanyam Gandhi of Chartered Speed, which has secured a 1,750-bus Bengaluru contract with EKA Mobility.

Olectra Greentech remains an outlier. While volumes rose to 853 units, its market share declined to 19.6 per cent as peers scaled faster.

However, a ₹1,800 crore Telangana order for 1,085 buses is expected to support a recovery, with deliveries likely to flow into FY27.

Bots take charge in the poll battlefield

From generating digital posters to decoding data, AI now powers political war rooms

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As campaigning gathers pace in the Assembly polls, the war rooms of major political parties have leaned on artificial intelligence (AI) to get the message across in a hyper-social media world. From recreating the voices of late leaders to producing targeted content and analysing public sentiment, AI is now a mainstream campaign tool.

Consider the way the Left Front used it in Kerala. When allegations surfaced about a supposed understanding with the NDA, the CPI(M) fired an explainer reel on the LDF government's decade-long achievements, using AI to generate the report card. Not to be outdone, BJP handles pushed content suggesting the CPI(M) and the Congress were "two sides of the same coin".



KEY TOOL. AI drives speed and strategy in poll campaigns

PR Shiva Shankar, the BJP candidate for the Ernakulam constituency, said that AI was reshaping political campaigning by enabling more informed, data-led strategies. Not only does AI offer a deeper understanding of public sentiment, it brings a cost and time effective dimension to outreach, he said.

DIGITAL DRIVE

Deepak Joy, Congress candidate from Thirupithura, said that while there is nothing inherently wrong in using AI to communicate party promises or highlight

opponents' shortcomings, it must be used carefully.

In Tamil Nadu, TRB Rajaa, Secretary, DMK IT Wing, said the party was actively integrating AI into its work, and found it useful. "It helps us craft digital content swiftly, analyse feedback and data, and also helps us interpret data better," he said. However good AI gets, in politics, human intelligence will continue to be the driving force.

The BJP has brought its national might to the Tamil Nadu polls with a central team sharing findings from its AI-powered sentiment

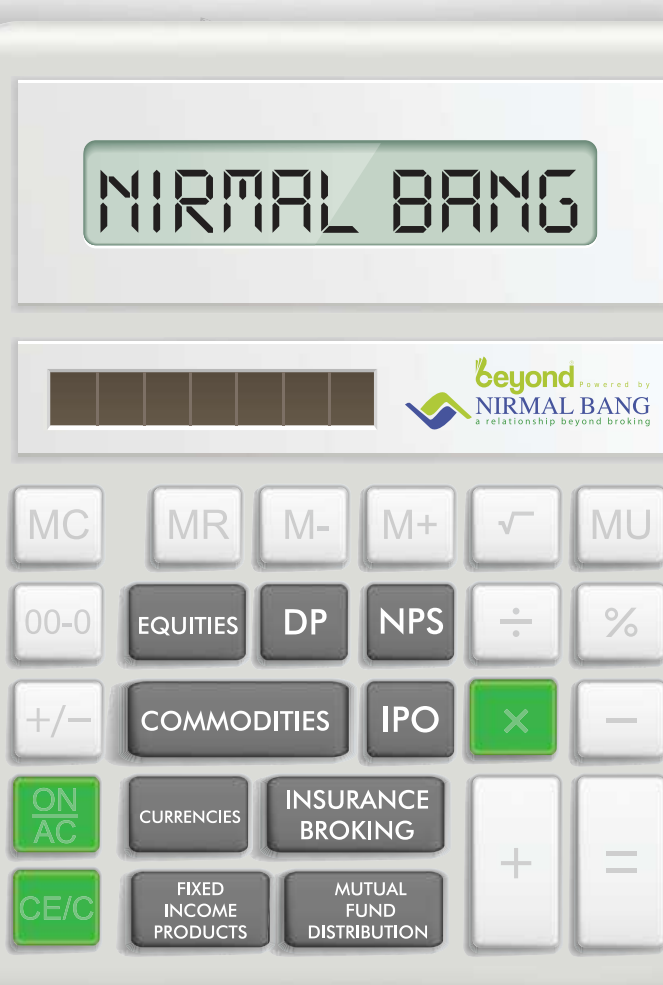
analysis tool to help local teams create campaigns.

SG Suryah, President, TN BJP Youth Wing, has a separate team working on AI strategies during these polls. His team said creating digital posters and video content is now done in minutes with the correct prompts. The team also uses AI for booth analysis to automate workflows and get reports on key constituencies, he added.

STRATEGY LAYER

Digital marketer Shubho Sengupta said that in 2024, AI was a production tool used for faster creatives, but in 2026, it is operating at the strategy layer for real-time constituency sentiment, micro-targeted messaging and candidate positioning adjusted mid-campaign on live data.

With inputs from Vinson Kurian and V Sajeer Kumar

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QUICKLY.

TAC Security clocks 10,000-client mark

Hyderabad: TAC Security, a cybersecurity solutions company, said that it crossed the 10,000-client mark since April 2024. This number includes over 6,500 clients added through TAC Security software solutions alongside 3,500-odd clients through Cyberscope. “The list of clients include Apple, Microsoft, Google, AWS, Samsung, Adobe, Salesforce and HSBC,” a statement said on Tuesday. “The company plans to deepen monetisation through a \$10,000 annual recurring revenue-per-client benchmark...” OUR BUREAU

Mindspace REIT acquires ₹2,541-cr Chennai office

Mumbai: Mindspace Business Parks REIT acquired a 2.6 million sq ft office in Chennai for an enterprise value of about ₹2,541 crore, marking a significant expansion in one of India's fastest-growing office markets. The REIT will acquire Sycamore Properties and Content Properties, which together own Commerzone Pallikarantai, a campus-style development located along Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam Road corridor. OUR BUREAU

‘Developing countries, LDCs can no longer be rule-takers at WTO’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Developing countries and least developed countries (LDCs) asserted themselves across critical areas such as agriculture, e-commerce and reform debates, at the WTO's 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14) in Yaoundé, Cameroon last week, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said.

“...developing countries &

India to face pressure as US seeks plurilateral e-comm moratorium

TRADE TIFF. New Delhi may need to align with Brazil and Turkey to safeguard policy

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer has said Washington will seek commitments from countries to pursue a plurilateral e-commerce duties moratorium agreement after Brazil and Turkey “blocked” its extension at the WTO Ministerial Conference in Yaoundé, a move that could put fresh pressure on India.

New Delhi, which has been questioning the moratorium citing rising revenue losses and the absence of clear definitions, may need to align with Brazil and Turkey to safeguard its policy space and preserve negotiating leverage, experts said.

“It is particularly frustrating that the WTO could not achieve consensus to make the e-commerce moratorium permanent or even to extend it for longer than two years,” Greer said in a statement naming Brazil and Turkey as the two countries that “blocked” extending it till December 31 2030.



If the WTO cannot achieve this common sense aim, the US will work outside of the WTO with all interested partners to get it done

JAMIESON GREER
US Trade Representative



WHAT IS IT? The WTO e-commerce moratorium, first agreed to in 1998 for a two-year term, is a temporary agreement not to impose customs duties on electronic transmissions.

This means that while physical goods are taxed at the border, digital equivalents — like software, e-books, and streaming services — remain duty-free. While the moratorium was being renewed every two years since its inception, it lapsed at the just-concluded WTO MC14 due to disagreement over the term.

The US has secured commitments from dozens of countries, and nearly all major trading partners, not to impose tariffs on US digital transmissions, the USTR asserted.

‘COMMON SENSE AIM’ “If the WTO cannot achieve this common sense aim, the US will work outside of the WTO with all interested partners to get it done. To that end, the US invites all trading partners to commit to a plurilateral e-commerce moratorium agreement,” Greer said.

A plurilateral agreement

includes a subset of countries, and not full membership. The ending of the e-commerce moratorium at MC14 is a historic moment, pointed out Parminder Jeet Singh, Founding Member, Just Net Coalition. “It can mark the start of developing nations viewing their digital economy through a lens of digital industrial policies, proper regulation of foreign firms, and getting all the due taxes from them, as most value flows across borders will soon be digital,” Singh told *businessline*.

India should support Brazil and Turkey as they stood up for the Global South countries which have been losing billions in potential revenue and policy space, said Ranja Sengupta, Senior Researcher, Third World Network, India.

“I don't see how a plurilateral will work as it means those who stay out do not cut tariffs on transmissions but others will. But there will be a lot of US pressure on developing countries to join if takes place,” Sengupta noted.

Unrealised tax demands rise to ₹38 lakh crore by FY25-end

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

Tax authorities have continued to raise tax demands, both in direct and indirect taxes, resulting in strong growth in unrealised tax demands in recent years.

Budget documents show that such unrealised tax demands amounted to more than ₹38 lakh crore towards the end of FY25.

DATA FOCUS.

A *businessline* analysis of Union Budget documents shows that these demands have been higher in direct taxes, with unrealised demands growing at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 26 per cent between FY20 and FY25.

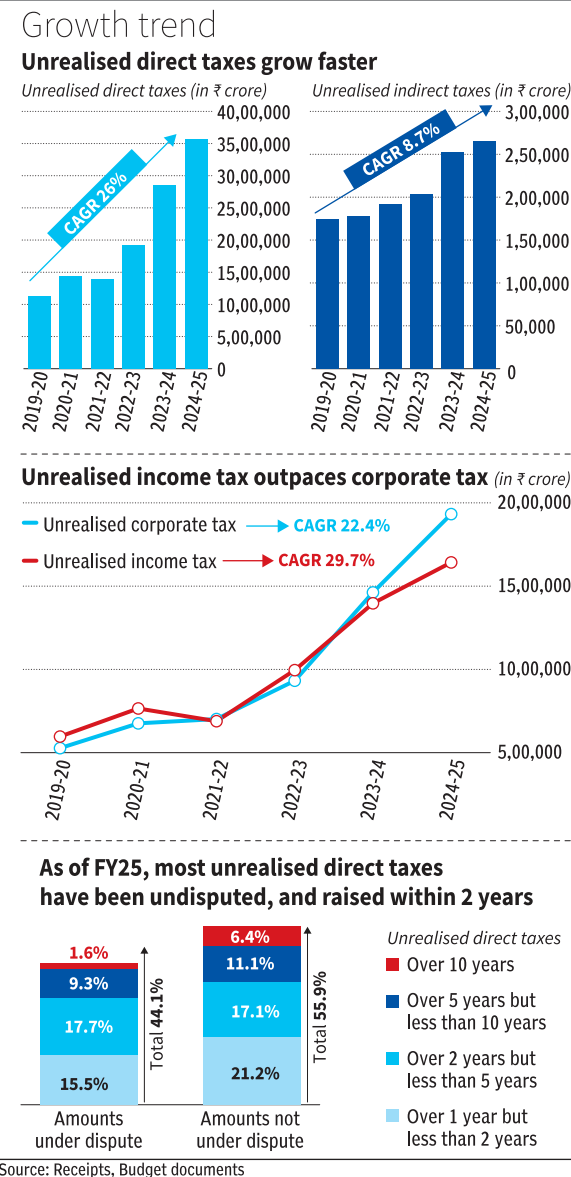
Growth in unrealised demands in indirect taxes was at a slower pace of 8.7 per cent annually over the same period.

The growth in unrealised direct tax demands has been striking, from ₹11 lakh crore in FY20, the figure rose to approximately ₹36 lakh crore in FY25, about a three-fold increase. Within this, income tax-related unrealised demands alone reached ₹19 lakh crore in FY25, growing faster than unrealised corporate tax demands, which stood at ₹16 lakh crore.

In comparison, unrealised indirect taxes grew at a slower pace, reaching ₹2.6 lakh crore in FY25 from ₹1.7 lakh crore in FY20. This divergence suggests that the bulk of aggressive tax assessments is concentrated in direct taxes, which raises concerns about the structural issues in tax administration.

The inordinately high backlog of unrealised tax demands suggests frivolous tax demands being issued by the I-T department in a bid to meet tax revenue targets.

With 44 per cent of these demands under litigation, enforceability is under question. In some cases, large de-



Sula plans resort at Chandon site as biz hits ₹100 crore

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Sula Vineyards, India's largest wine company, is planning a resort at recently acquired Chandon winery in Dindori, Nashik, as its wine tourism business crosses ₹100 crore in revenue for the first time, accounting for a fifth of its total turnover.

Monit Ravindra Dhavale, Head of Hospitality, confirmed the plan at Dindori, which Sula acquired from LVMH's Moët Hennessy, after the French luxury group exited India citing underperformance. “Very soon we are going to announce... it is going to take time to build,” he told *businessline*.

The location benefits from proximity to fresh MIDC investments by Reliance Life Sciences and Godrej, and expanding air link to Nashik — from Delhi, Bengaluru, Ahmedabad, Goa and Indore, and a Kolkata service starting June.

E4W registrations up 88% in FY26

T E Raja Simhan
Amit Vijay Mohile
Chennai/Mumbai

Electric passenger vehicle (e4W) registrations in India saw a sharp surge in FY26, rising 88 per cent on-year to 1.91 lakh units from 1.01 lakh in the previous fiscal, according to Vahan data, reflecting strong consumer demand and an expanding product line-up.

Market leader Tata Motors retained the top position but saw its market share decline to 38.7 per cent in FY26 from 53.3 per cent a year ago, indicating intensifying competition. JSW MG Motor, the second-largest player, also witnessed a drop in share.

In contrast, Mahindra Electric Automobile posted a sharp rise, with market share climbing to 20.8 per cent from 7.5 per cent, emerging as a strong challenger. The company, along with new entrants VinFast and Maruti Suzuki — which began regis-

Steady growth		(in numbers)	
	2025-26	Market share (%)	2024-25
Tata Passenger Electric Mobility	74,021	38.71	53,913
JSW MG Motor	51,852	27.12	29,393
Mahindra Electric	39,804	20.82	7,662
Hyundai	5,791	3.03	2,477
BYD	5,077	2.66	3,346

Source: Vahan data collated at 4 pm on March 31, 2026

trations during the fiscal — drove volumes in the second half.

Notably, in March alone, Maruti Suzuki and VinFast displaced JSW MG Motor and BYD India to claim the fourth and fifth spots, respectively, highlighting the rapidly evolving competitive landscape. Industry experts attributed the surge to new product launches and a deepening pipeline. Models such as the Maruti e-Vitara, Mahindra XEV 9s, and Tata Punch EV — absent a year ago — have significantly boosted volumes, said Gaurav Vangaal of S&P

Global Mobility. With more launches planned annually, EV penetration is expected to increase further.

Vinkesh Gulati, former President of Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations and Chairman of Automotive Skills Development Council, noted that the top three players now control nearly 87 per cent of the market, signalling a shift from a single-leader phase to a “high-growth, competitive triopoly”.

LONG-TERM CASE According to Crisil Ratings' Director Poonam Upadhyay,

improved charging infrastructure, wider OEM participation, and enhancements in range and features could accelerate further adoption. Ongoing geopolitical volatility in West Asia is also reinforcing the long-term case for electrification by underscoring fuel price and supply uncertainties, she added.

Kranthi Bathini of WealthMills Securities observed that the EV market is becoming increasingly crowded, with a “second wave” of players — Maruti Suzuki, VinFast, and Hyundai — collectively contributing over 2,000 units a month.

Another analyst pointed out a significant structural shift with JSW MG Motor and Mahindra Electric together having overtaken Tata Motors, swinging from a combined deficit of 17,000 units last year to a surplus of over 17,000 units this year. This marks a transition from a leader-dominated market to a more competitive, multi-player ecosystem, the analyst said.

Cargill India posts double-digit growth; B2B segment emerges key growth pillar

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Global food corporation Cargill is witnessing double-digit growth in India with B2B business emerging as a key growth pillar. It is leveraging its innovation centre in the country to develop and co-create solutions with food manufacturers, when evolving consumers are increasingly seeking healthier and premium food options.

“Over the past six and half months, we have been witnessing double-digit growth, close to mid-teens. We have a strong B2C business in the country. At the same time, India has become an important growth enabler for the B2B business for the overall Asia-Pacific region for us. Given the evolving needs of Indian consumers and the requirements of food manu-



Dheeraj Talreja, Vice-President & MD Cargill Food South Asia

factors, we believe future growth will come more strongly from the B2B business,” Dheeraj Talreja, Vice-President & Managing Director, Cargill Food South Asia, told *businessline*.

HEALTHIER OPTIONS In terms of the B2B business, Talreja noted that the company is witnessing strong growth in segments such as

healthier food product solutions, bakery as well as chocolate and confectionery segments.

“As consumers are increasingly seeking healthier food options, we are working closely with food manufacturers to co-create and develop solutions that are commercially viable and ready to scale. Health and nutrition now cuts across segments. We are also bringing many global food solutions to India. So, whether it is protein fortification, oil reduction, premium chocolate formats or reformulation, we are helping food manufacturers navigate the dynamic landscape of balancing cost pressures with their growth ambitions,” he added. He noted India's per capita chocolate consumption is much lower than developed economies.

ACME signs ₹20,000 crore green ammonia deal with SECI for 10 years

Our Bureau
Mumbai

ACME Group signed a 10-year binding Green Ammonia Purchase Agreement (GAPA) with the Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI) on Monday, committing to supply 370,000 tonnes per annum (TPA) of green ammonia at an estimated



The deal entails the supply of 3,70,000 tonnes of green ammonia annually under India's SIGHT scheme

ated contract value of ₹20,000 crore over the contract period.

The deal, executed under the Government of India's SIGHT Scheme Mode-2A, Tranche-I — the country's first green hydrogen and am-

monia procurement programme — follows letters of award that ACME received from SECI in August and September 2025.

SUPPLY NETWORK Under the agreement, ACME will build a green ammonia production facility in Odisha.

The output will be distributed to six fertilizer plants across five States. SECI, acting as the intermediary aggregator, has separately signed Green Ammonia Sale Agreements (GASA) with the offtake companies. The buyers (and their contracted volumes) are: IFFCO's Kandla plant in Gujarat (1,00,000 TPA) and Paradeep plant in Odisha (1,00,000 TPA); Paradeep Phosphates

Ltd at Paradeep, Odisha (75,000 TPA) and Goa (25,000 TPA); India Potash Ltd at Haldia, West Bengal (20,000 TPA); and Coromandel International at Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh (50,000 TPA).

COMMERCIAL USE ACME COO for Green Hydrogen and Ammonia Anil Taparia said the agreement demonstrates commercial-scale viability of green ammonia production and off-take at competitive cost.

The company already operates a pilot-scale green hydrogen and ammonia plant and is developing large-scale green ammonia and green methanol projects in India and Oman for both domestic and export markets.

E-autos: Mahindra, Bajaj, TVS in 3-way race

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

India's electric three-wheeler market is turning into a three-way contest in FY26, with Mahindra Last Mile Mobility leading the high-speed electric auto (L5) segment at over 91,000 units and around 35 per cent market share, closely followed by Bajaj Auto at more than 87,000 units and over 33 per cent.

TVS Motor, with over 27,000 units, has emerged as a fast-growing challenger, taking its share to double digits.

DECISIVE SHIFT The shift comes as electric autos decisively outpace e-rickshaws. L5 volumes surged 65 per cent year-on-year to 262,683 units, while



low-speed e-rickshaws (L3) grew just 4 per cent to 561,154 units. Overall registrations rose 18 per cent to 823,837 units, with electric autos contributing over 100,000 units, accounting for more than 80 per cent of incremental growth. As a result, L5 share rose to nearly 32 per cent from about 23 per cent, while L3 fell below 70 per cent.

“This is the first clear inflection point where electric

platforms, including the Riki range (5.4 kWh battery, up to 164 km range) aimed at the mass segment, alongside the higher-end WEGO with a 17.7 kWh battery and nearly 300 km range. Mahindra has introduced the UDO electric auto with an 11.7 kWh battery and around 200 km real-world range.

Among challengers, Omega Seiki's NRG (~15 kWh, up to 300 km) targets cargo fleets, while Euler focuses on high-payload logistics and TI Clean Mobility (Montra) on premium positioning. Piaggio has upgraded its Apé Elektrik range with improved efficiency and swappable battery options.

“What we are seeing is a shift from a fragmented market to one where scale, distribution and financing access are becoming critical,” another analyst said.

Existential crisis

WTO needs to rediscover its raison d’ etre

The recently concluded WTO Ministerial at Cameroon throws up two distinct sets of questions. The proverbial elephant in the room, of course, concerns the organisation’s relevance at a time when the rules of the game in global trade have been entirely upended. On this, the meet offers little succour. The second deals with the implications of what actually happened at the latest meet.



On the latter, there were two interesting developments, where India laudably stood its ground. Along with Brazil and Turkey, India opposed the extension of the 28-year moratorium on tariffs on e-commerce goods. Not surprisingly, the US is incensed. India needs to reserve the sovereign right to tax digital transactions, even as it offers concessions from time to time. The digital economy accounted for about 11 per cent of India’s GDP for FY23, with artificial intelligence set to raise this share. Such a stand aligns with past policy. The government removed tax-free benefits for IT industry in 2009 when it was seen capable of thriving without support. Today, when Big Tech wants to prise open India’s market, it must be willing to pay for it. It is heartening that India has not mixed up its position with its trade talks with the US.

India also rightly resisted the China-backed Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) proposal, arguing that plurilateral deals have no place in a multilateral body. Here, a select group of nations agree on a proposal and try to get the WTO’s approval. However, what has not been satisfactorily resolved is the moratorium on certain TRIPS-related complaints. Thanks to this moratorium, India has been able to implement the Patents Act by disregarding minor innovations or ‘evergreening’, assuring access to affordable medicines and other products for its people. It is also to be noted here that investment facilitation pacts have always been controversial. The Western demand for transparency in such deals could clash with a developing country’s policy space. In fact, it is possible that the erstwhile PN3 would have perhaps run foul of such an investment pact. It is, however, another matter that IFD was opposed on grounds of process.

Finally, WTO has strayed away from the 1994 Marrakesh script of ‘trade for development’ and removal of poverty. The principle of consensus between big and small, the Global North and South, has been jettisoned. The US has run it down. What really showed up the toothlessness of the WTO was its inability to resist the Liberation Day tariffs — which tear apart the very basis of fair trade, by doing way with uniform tariffs for a single product. There are few indications so far of China playing the game fairly either, as it seeks to push its own interests. There is also the problem of FTA agreements running foul of WTO principles; India too has allowed such inconsistencies to creep in. With the emergence of new alliances and supply chains, WTO truly needs a ‘third force’ to stay alive.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



What happens when CAD rises

TIME LAG. Speed of adjustment to normal levels can vary across countries. In India’s case, this adjustment has been slow



SAUMITRA BHADURI
SHUBHAM ANAND

The escalation of conflict in the Middle East has pushed global oil prices higher, exposing a familiar fault line in India’s external position. Despite robust domestic growth, the rupee has slipped to record lows and equity markets have turned volatile. Why has strong growth and contained inflation not insulated the currency? In the near term, oil and risk premia dominate pricing when patient capital is scarce.

This is a flow story overwhelming a stock story: war-driven energy shocks and a stronger dollar have collided with thinner, more flighty capital inflows — pressures that overwhelm fundamentals in the short run and take years to adjust. Let’s understand this better.

THE DISCONNECT

On paper, India’s macro story is reassuring: growth projected at 7.4 per cent this fiscal, inflation relatively contained, reserves near \$701.4 billion, a current account deficit (CAD) of about 0.8 per cent of GDP, and resilient services exports and remittances. Yet the rupee fell by more than 5 per cent last year and has hovered near recent lows. The proximate drivers are clear. As a large oil importer, India’s dollar demand jumps when crude spikes, widening the trade deficit and squeezing corporate margins; at the same time, a stronger dollar tightens global financial conditions.

Ordinarily, a modest CAD is easily financed, but in 2025 foreign portfolio investors pulled back and net FDI softened as profit repatriation and outbound investment rose. That shift changed the market’s risk calculus. With less patient capital, the rupee became more sensitive to shifts in risk appetite. As oil buyers needed more dollars just as investors sought safety, the rupee took a hit from both sides.

RUPEE DYNAMICS

Why couldn’t fundamentals defend it quickly? In the short run, risk and oil premia price the currency. In the long run, fair value anchors it.

On that front, we tried understanding the rupee dynamics, and purchasing power parity (PPP) offers one such long-run compass. It indicates where the

Speed of adjustment towards PPP equilibrium of different countries

Country	Months					
	12	24	36	48	60	72
Brazil	0.2	0.38	0.65	0.98	1.24	1.46
Canada	0.16	0.31	0.48	0.69	0.91	1.09
Chile	0.19	0.38	0.69	0.96	1.23	1.39
China	0.15	0.29	0.36	0.43	0.56	0.67
Colombia	0.18	0.32	0.54	0.84	1.13	1.34
Czech Republic	0.14	0.22	0.31	0.46	0.58	0.72
Denmark	0.23	0.47	0.62	0.83	1.08	1.28
France	0.2	0.44	0.64	0.85	1.09	1.28
Hungary	0.18	0.3	0.4	0.59	0.77	0.96
Iceland	0.47	0.87	1.07	1.3	1.45	1.42
India	0.13	0.2	0.25	0.33	0.44	0.54
Indonesia	0.48	0.69	0.83	1.08	1.15	1.2
Japan	0.05	0.21	0.35	0.35	0.33	0.42
Mexico	0.36	0.51	0.6	0.72	0.82	0.92
Norway	0.11	0.23	0.34	0.55	0.77	0.99
Russia	0.31	0.54	0.66	0.72	0.75	0.9
South Africa	0.22	0.48	0.66	0.8	0.9	0.9
Sweden	0.15	0.32	0.43	0.6	0.8	0.94
Switzerland	0.28	0.55	0.71	0.94	1.13	1.21
United Kingdom	0.18	0.31	0.37	0.49	0.58	0.51

Source: Compiled by authors

currency tends to settle once shocks fade. From that perspective, our pre-shock estimate placed the rupee roughly 18 per cent below PPP fair value (also referred to as “equilibrium” in economic literature).

We computed equilibrium using monthly real exchange rate (RER) data for more than three decades, following PPP theory that RER exhibit a mean-reverting behaviour.

The key nuance is speed: India’s adjustment towards PPP is slow (as shown in the Figure), with a half-life of more than five years, meaning only half of any misalignment typically closes over that horizon.

For instance, in one year, only 13 per cent of the adjustment towards equilibrium is completed; in three years, only 25 per cent; and in five years, just 44 per cent.

Several emerging peers, such as Brazil

or Indonesia, appear to adjust faster.

Also, we observed that these adjustments are also uneven: when the currency is far from equilibrium, corrections often arrive abruptly during risk-off episodes and outflows. Put simply, even when fundamentals are sound, the path back to equilibrium is long and bumpy — too slow to offset a sudden oil-and-dollar shock. This explains the current dynamics.

THE TRANSMISSION

Because India imports most of its crude, pricier oil raises the import bill before quantities adjust, widening the CAD and pressuring the rupee. Some of the hit is cushioned by the service surplus and remittances, as well as heading and pricing policies that delay pass-through. Over time, higher prices can curb demand, induce efficiency and alter the terms of trade, gradually narrowing the gap.

Multi-country evidence suggests that for oil importers, a 1 per cent real oil price shock — that is, a 1 per cent increase in the oil price after adjusting for inflation using the US consumer price index — can worsen the current account balance (CAB) by up to 0.08

War-driven energy shocks and a stronger dollar have collided with thinner, more flighty capital inflows

A holistic approach needed on menstrual leave

SC has refrained from issuing a blanket directive. Policymakers should balance social protection with economic opportunity

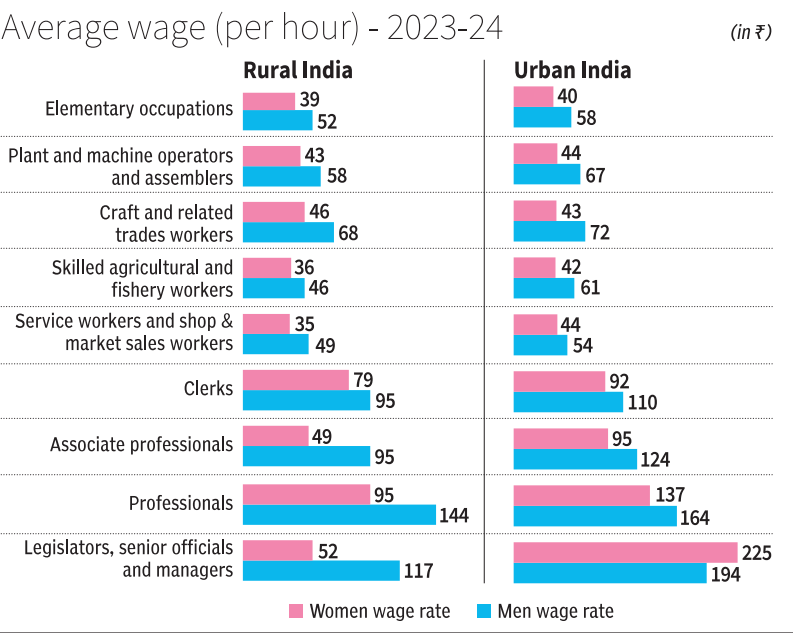
Dona Ghosh
Chandril Bhattacharyya

On March 13, 2026, the Supreme Court declined to consider a petition that sought a nationwide policy on menstrual leave for women students and employees. The court noted that the demand was rooted in genuine concern for women’s health. However, it also expressed caution. Judges observed that making such leave compulsory could reinforce gender stereotypes. It could also affect hiring decisions and limit job opportunities for women.

The ruling has sparked debate across legal and social circles. Supporters of menstrual leave say menstruation is a natural biological process. For many women, it involves pain, fatigue and emotional stress. These challenges can be severe, especially for those in physically demanding jobs.

Women working long shifts or without flexible schedules may find it hard to cope. In such cases, the absence of supportive policies can result in lost income or declining health. Advocates argue that recognising menstrual health at the workplace is a matter of dignity and fairness.

Economists and industry groups have raised concerns about the economic impact of mandatory leave. They point



out that paid menstrual leave could increase labour costs for firms. This is particularly important for small and medium enterprises that operate on thin profit margins. Employers may try to adjust by offering lower starting wages to women. Some may reduce hiring or rely more on short-term contracts.

In addition, entry-level wages may be the first to see such adjustments. In highly competitive sectors, this could slow career progression for women. Without strong anti-discrimination rules, the risk of widening pay gaps may increase. Wage data also reveal existing inequalities. Women’s earnings are

percentage points (pp) of GDP over five years, while improving oil exporters’ balances by up to 0.9pp in emerging markets (World Bank, 2023). For India, a sustained 10 per cent real increase in oil could translate into roughly 0.8pp of deterioration in the CAB over five years, and a sustained 20 per cent increase about 1.6pp; a persistent 5 per cent increase could imply around 0.4pp. These are cumulative pressures — buffers mute them, but do not eliminate them. Unless capital inflows deepen and diversify, these current-account stresses transmit into the currency during shock years.

PATH FORWARD

The rupee’s recent struggles underscore a deeper reality: its trajectory is shaped not only by fundamentals, but by sensitivity to external shocks and capital composition. Durable currency strength requires more than growth and low inflation; it requires resilience in the flow dynamics that matter most during stress.

Near-term shock absorbers include calibrated fuel-tax adjustments to smooth pass-through while protecting fiscal anchors, deploying FX reserves opportunistically to counter disorderly moves rather than to target levels, and strengthening risk management for oil imports through diversified sourcing and prudent hedging.

Medium-term insulation means attracting and retaining higher-quality, “stickier” capital, especially greenfield FDI — by maintaining a stable, predictable policy regime, depending on local-currency financing markets, and reducing policy uncertainty that widens risk premia.

Long-term competitiveness depends on sustainably strengthening the external position by raising export complexity and scale in manufacturing, while accelerating energy security — diversifying crude sources, expanding strategic reserves, speeding the renewables transition, and improving energy efficiency.

Every crisis carries a lesson. This one should prompt policymakers to treat energy security and capital quality as central pillars of external stability, not peripheral goals. By turning a recurring oil-and-flows vulnerability into a managed risk — through better shock absorbers, deeper and steadier inflows, and higher export competitions, India can safeguard the currency through well-calibrated policy responses.

Bhaduri is Professor, and Anand is PhD scholar, Madras School of Economics, Chennai

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Rupee’s trajectory fragile

Apropos, ‘Rupee doing fine compared to other emerging economies: FM’ (March 31). The rupee continues to face persistent depreciatory pressures amid escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia, elevated crude oil prices, and sustained capital outflows. The RBI’s recent imposition of a \$100-million cap on banks’ net open foreign exchange positions triggered a sharp, liquidity-driven appreciation. However, such regulatory-induced corrections lack durability. Absent substantive improvements in macroeconomic fundamentals, external balances, and capital

inflows, the rupee’s trajectory remains inherently fragile.

N Sadhasiva Reddy
Bengaluru

Supply chain hindrances

‘The global economy’s many chokepoints’ (March 31) is a timely reminder about the disastrous supply chain disruptions. The impact of the closure of Strait of Hormuz is reverberating across world economies and the consequences could last long. The next big chokepoint could be the rare earths, which are vital for tech-led global economic growth. The control and processing of rare

earths are largely concentrated in the hands of China. The world must wake up quickly and strive to build resilient supply chains through cooperation.

Kosaraju Chandramouli
Hyderabad

RBI’s bag of tricks

Apropos ‘Bond Blues’ (March 31), the RBI faces a tough remit of containing yields without diluting its inflation-fighting credibility. Deft open market operations like Operation Twist of 2019 — of long term interest management — could smooth the yield curve. Liquidity management can be through tested

devices as variable rate repos/reverse repo to arrest abrupt spikes. Clear forward guidance will be critical to anchor market expectations. If pressures intensify, limited devolvement support or green-shoe options in auctions may be used to stabilise demand.

R Narayanan
Navi Mumbai

Ecological vandalism

The relentless commodification of our last pristine landscapes is nothing short of ecological vandalism. We treat bio-corridors like theme parks ignoring that human intrusion disrupts critical carbon

sequestration. For instance the foothills in the Himalayas have surged by 40 per cent in a decade. The result is a trail of plastic and receding glaciers.

When pleasure activities are permitted in eco-sensitive zones we trade millennia of biodiversity for transient revenue. Statistics suggest that nearly 75 per cent of terrestrial environments are severely altered by human activity. We must designate biological hotspots as absolute no-go zones. Governments must strictly enforce inviolable zones and cancel destructive permits.

Vijaykumar HK
Raichur, Karnataka

Domestic safeguards

Trade remedies, a vital tool to protect Indian firms

Rajiv Arora

In an era defined by escalating trade wars, supply chain nationalism, and the strategic use of tariffs as geopolitical instruments, one would expect India to lean more heavily on trade remedies (TRs). These legitimate, WTO-sanctioned tools are available to governments to protect domestic industries from unfair or disruptive import practices.

As global trade patterns shift sharply, domestic industry needs to be protected through anti-dumping duties, countervailing measures, and other safeguards.

Yet, the Finance Ministry's recent rejection of nearly 85 per cent of positive recommendations from the Commerce Ministry for the imposition of TRs is counter-intuitive. Is this simply an unusual coincidence, or is it the first signal of a policy shift toward discouraging the use of TRs?

India has long been a major user of trade remedies, primarily anti-dumping (AD) and safeguard measures. Globally too, trade remedies have been a preferred instrument, despite a chequered history shaped by techno-legal complexities and public interest concerns.

India's application of trade remedies has been notably rule-bound and restrained, often limited to the quantum necessary to mitigate injury and, in many cases, set below the WTO-permitted ceiling of fully offsetting dumping or subsidy.

WTO COMPLIANT

WTO rules allow a country to impose anti-dumping duties up to the full margin of dumping, which is the gap between the export price and the normal value in the exporting country. However, the Lesser Duty Rules (LDR) caps the duty at the level sufficient only to remove injury to the domestic industry.

While the LDR no doubt balances stakeholder interests, the downside is that it may fail to deter repeat dumping, thereby contributing to recurring trade remedy petitions. Until 2020, the Finance Ministry rejected fewer than 1 per cent of DGTR's recommendations.

As globalisation deepened, the tensions within value chains intensified, especially where trade remedies were repeatedly used at specific stages. Anti-dumping measures have often drawn criticism for protectionist overreach and for distorting



TRADE REMEDIES. Tough calls GETTY IMAGES

supply chains, particularly for MSMEs, even when such measures are justified under WTO rules. The Covid-19 crisis amplified this tension, with supply-chain continuity often taking precedence over industry protection. It was in this context that the Finance Ministry rejected a high number of DGTR recommendations in 2020.

But since January 2026, 16 cases, or about 85 per cent of the total, have been rejected, with no clear correlation with either public interest or industry type. This raises the possibility that the Finance Ministry may have attributed the injury in these cases to factors other than dumping.

If that is indeed the underlying rationale, India may be better served by an institutional mechanism to examine such divergences more transparently. An inter-ministerial standing board, akin to the safeguard-action framework, could be constituted to review DGTR recommendations before a final decision is taken by the Finance Ministry.

Likewise, a structured and transparent public-interest inquiry, on the lines of the European Union model, could help assess public-interest concerns arising from anti-dumping recommendations. Such a framework would improve transparency, preserve institutional balance, and sustain confidence in trade remedies as a legitimate policy tool.

Trade remedies are carefully negotiated instruments of the multilateral trading system, designed precisely for the kind of disrupted global trade environment India now faces. They should not be allowed to atrophy through unexplained rejections at an unprecedented rate, especially in an exceptionally volatile and uncertain global environment.

The writer is former Additional Secretary, Ministry of Commerce

For a permanent ‘stabilisation fund’

CRISIS CONTROL. It should be institutionalised by statute, with States as stakeholders – and not just a response to crises



S ADIKESAVAN

The creation of an Economic Stabilisation Fund by the Finance Ministry signals the need for institutional mechanisms to respond to shocks. As of now, the Fund's creation appears to be a response to recent geopolitical and economic disruptions. While presenting the Supplementary Demands for Grants, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman remarked: “In an era marked by heightened global uncertainty, India must equip itself with dedicated institutional buffers to safeguard economic stability. The Economic Stabilisation Fund is envisioned as a forward-looking instrument to ensure that unforeseen shocks do not derail our growth trajectory.”

Globally, there are few precedents for such a fund. While several advanced economies have established large sovereign wealth funds (SWFs), these are not directly comparable, as SWFs are typically designed for long-term asset management rather than short-term macroeconomic stabilisation.

DEALING WITH CRISES

In recent decades, governments worldwide have relied predominantly on fiscal measures to counter economic disruptions.

The global financial crisis of 2008 and the Covid-19 pandemic are instructive examples. In both instances, expansionary fiscal policies — manifested through increased public spending and higher deficits — proved effective in cushioning economic downturns and supporting recovery.

If the ongoing conflict in West Asia worsens, India may be compelled to expand its fiscal deficit. This raises an important question: can we not structure and formalise such responses to ensure both effectiveness and sustainability?

A critical distinction must be noted here. Neither during the 2008 crisis nor



TRANSPARENCY. The Fund's governance must be overseen by an independent group insulated from political considerations GETTY IMAGES

the Covid-19 pandemic did governments resort to outright monetary expansion in the form of large-scale money printing as a primary tool. Instead, deficit financing was largely achieved through increased borrowing. In India's case, this borrowing has been predominantly in domestic currency, thereby insulating the economy from exchange rate risks. During the pandemic, fiscal deficits rose to over 9 per cent of GDP without triggering any destabilising consequence. It has tapered now to about 4.5 per cent. This suggests that, under certain conditions, higher deficits can be managed without undermining stability.

Therefore, the key challenge lies in

The key challenge lies in designing the Fund in a manner that allows it to function as a reliable, flexible, transparent and a longish buffer against future shocks

designing the Fund in a manner that allows it to function as a reliable, flexible, transparent and a longish buffer against future shocks.

FIVE STEPS

Five broad steps could help anchor this initiative within India's long-term economic strategy.

First, there must be a clear legislative framework. The objectives, scope, and governance structure of the Fund should be articulated through Parliament, even if incorporated within the Finance Bill — similar to the statutory basis provided to the Monetary Policy Committee. At the same time, the framework must retain sufficient flexibility to address unforeseen contingencies. Given the nature of crises, the government of the day should have the authority to deploy funds swiftly, even without prior parliamentary approval in emergency situations. The Fund should not come under the purview of the CAG/CVC/CBI in the normal course.

Second, the Fund should be supported by regular annual allocations from the Union Budget, even in the

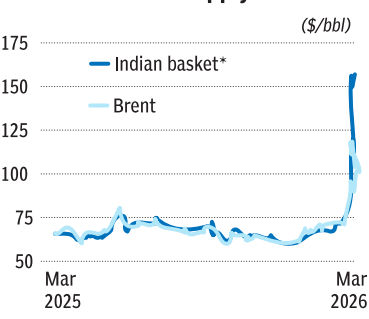
STATISTALK.

Compiled Dhuraveil Gunasekaran | Graphic Visveswaran V

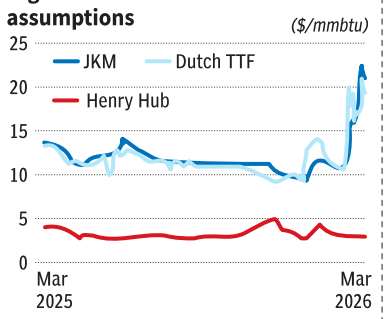
Energy shock from West Asia puts India's FY27 Budget under strain

The West Asia conflict has triggered a sharp surge in crude and gas prices, significantly complicating India's fiscal calculations for FY27, an ICRA report says. With Brent and the Indian crude basket rising steeply, and LNG prices nearly doubling, subsidy burdens for Fertilizer and LPG are set to overshoot Budget allocations. ICRA estimates that the Fertilizer subsidy alone could exceed the Budget by ₹400 billion. Elevated crude prices may also force excise duty cuts, risking significant revenue losses. Meanwhile, tax and dividend inflows from petroleum companies could weaken as refining margins shrink. Key facts.

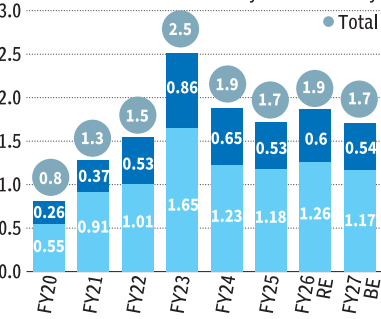
Crude oil prices double in March 2026 on West Asia supply shock



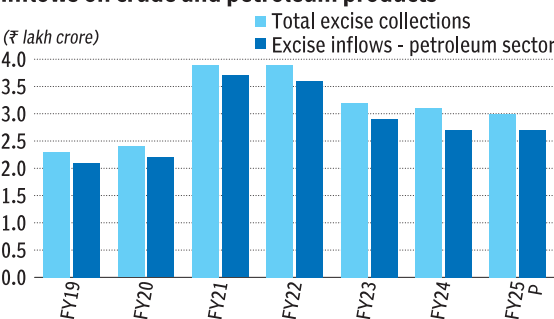
Gas prices mirror crude volatility, together threaten India's fiscal assumptions



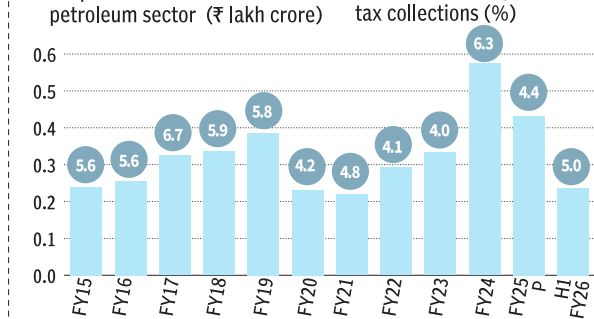
Annual trends in Fertilizer subsidy



Gol's aggregate excise duty collections and excise inflows on crude and petroleum products



Corporate tax collections from the petroleum sector



*The Indian basket of Crude Oil represents a derived basket comprising of Sour grade (Oman & Dubai average) and Sweet grade (Brent Dated) of Crude oil processed in Indian refineries, in the ratio of 78.71 : 21.29. This does not reflect the average price of India's crude oil imports; JKM: Japan Korea Marker; Source: CMIE; ICRA Research

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

April 1, 2006

STPI units eligible for IT sops

The Finance Ministry has said that Software Technology Park of India (STPI) units should not be denied tax exemption under Section 10 A of the income-tax law merely on the grounds that approval to such units have been granted by the directors of the STPIs and that such parks have not been approved by the Central Government.

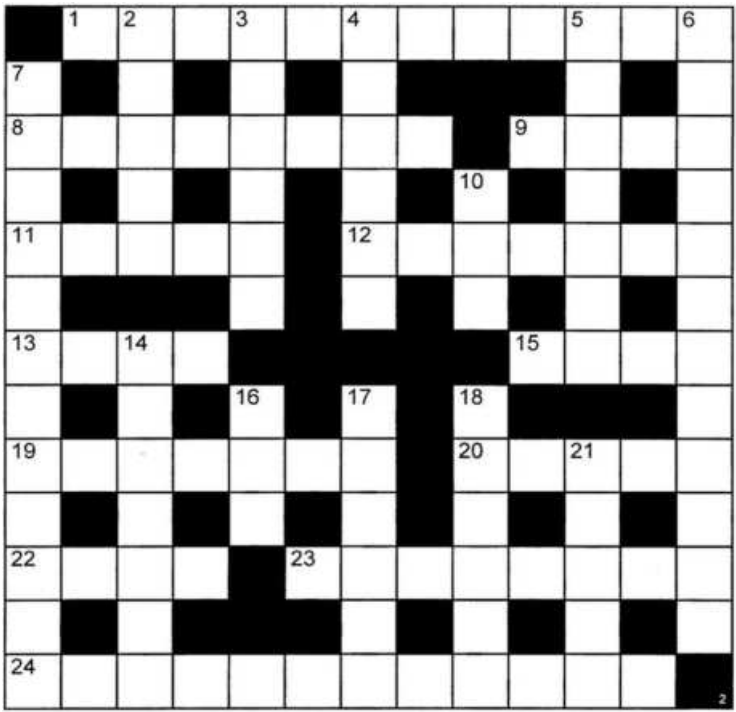
Videocon-GAIL group bags Oman contract

Only days after making public its acquisition bid for Daewoo Electronics of South Korea, Indian consumer durables major Videocon Industries Ltd has gone prospecting for oil in Oman. The company informed the stock exchanges on Friday that a consortium that includes GAIL (India), BPCL, HPCL and Oilx of Australia had been awarded Block 56 in Oman for exploration and further development.

Norms eased for unlisted cos raising money from abroad

The Government has eased the domestic listing rule for unlisted companies that raised money from overseas markets through foreign currency convertible bonds (FCCBs), American depository receipts/global depository receipts (GDRs) issued in terms of guidelines of May 1998 and are not making profit.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2648



EASY

ACROSS

- One working in association with another (12)
- Coping with (8)
- Record (4)
- That in which one excels (5)
- Lamp-case (7)
- Ultimate (4)
- Attar (4)
- Polish by rubbing (7)
- Rotate into coincidence with another plane (5)
- Superficial extent (4)
- Satisfy as to truth or error (8)
- A sect (12)

DOWN

- Proprietor (5)
- Lay lazily about (6)
- Act in a clumsy manner (6)
- Three-pronged spear (7)
- Examines with view to military operation (12)
- Shove-ha'penny (12)
- Unit number (3)
- Operating doctor (7)
- Establish, drive in, settle (3)
- Having been unseated (6)
- Hedge plant (6)
- Form of lotto (5)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- He helps the enemy to local bar, or puts him out (12)
- Dealing with the cards one is dealt on the heather (8)
- Record is concealed within it (4)
- It is one's strength to play it loudly (5)
- The light case at the top of a dome (7)
- Be enduring as a shoemaker's model (4)
- Rose essence to be taken back and forth (4)
- To polish, rub and endlessly shine it (7)
- Rotate into another plane when some grab attention (5)
- Extent to which some square arrangement is put (4)
- Satisfy one it's true no nice VC is handed out (8)
- How many pounds a note represents to a religious sect (12)

DOWN

- Captain of warship now re-assigned (5)
- Lazed around with the Spanish doll (6)
- Make a clumsy mistake giving a bribe to the French (6)
- Weapon I'd found in a river (7)
- Makes preliminary examination RI centre, soon dismantled (12)
- 'Make' the cards the directors use for game (12)
- A singular turn-up in the North (3)
- He may administer cuts while one's out (7)
- An awkward situation one can mend (3)
- Is off one's horse and on the canvas? (6)
- Quietly bolt it to the hedge (6)
- Game with cards and no big shuffle (5)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2647

ACROSS 1. Ballot 8. Enrol 9. Conform 11. Tangible 12. Jetty 15. Farm 16. Wax 17. Aloe 19. First 21. Quandary 24. Yatagan 25. Annul 26. Dredge

DOWN 2. Adobe 3. Lifetime 4. Tort 5. Wedge 6. Grab 7. Blue 10. Mandatory 12. Jiff 13. Navigate 14. Beat 18. Adult 20. Slang 21. Quay 22. Aunt 23. Yard

QUICKLY.

INOX Air Products
plans \$1 billion IPO

Mumbai: INOX Air Products is planning to launch a \$1 billion initial public offering in Mumbai, and has appointed Kotak, JPMorgan and Citi to manage the same, three sources familiar with the matter said. The company is a joint venture between American industrial gas maker Air Products and Chemicals and India's INOX Group. It plans to file papers with SEBI to seek approval within a month, two of the sources said. REUTERS

Coforge gets RBI nod for
\$1 b overseas Encora deal

Bengaluru: Coforge has received approval from the RBI for overseas direct investment exceeding \$1 billion, marking a step forward in its proposed acquisition of Encora, the company said in a stock exchange filing. The approval, granted under the Foreign Exchange Management (Overseas Investment) Rules, clears a key regulatory hurdle for the transaction involving Encora US Holdco Inc and Encora Holdings. OUR BUREAU

SEBI allows mutual funds to keep retirement, children’s schemes alive

REGULATION PUSH. AMC’s prepare for expense ratio cut implementation from today

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

In a significant relief to mutual funds and investors, capital markets regulator SEBI has reversed its decision to scrap retirement and children funds and allowed mutual funds to continue accepting inflows in these schemes, which have an asset base of ₹57,663 crore.

The industry claimed that investors will incur huge tax liabilities if the two ‘solution-oriented’ fund categories are closed and merged with comparable schemes.

“SEBI has addressed the concerns raised by the industry and investors by allowing retirement and children’s funds to continue, as there are a lot of nitty-gritty and tax components involved in the closure of these funds,” said DP Singh, Deputy Managing Director and Joint CEO, SBI Mutual Fund.



INVESTOR BURDEN. The industry claimed that investors would incur huge tax liabilities if the two fund categories were closed and merged with comparable schemes

Following this, MF industry players offering these funds have been allowed to continue them by foregoing the launch of two of the six proposed life-cycle funds, he added.

In February, SEBI had directed the discontinuation of such schemes and their merger with other schemes having a similar asset allocation and risk profile.

There are 44 schemes under these two categories, of which 29 are retirement

schemes and 15 are children’s funds.

NEW NORMS

Meanwhile, the asset management industry is also set to comply with the new norms for the sector from April 1, including a restructured expense framework, more disclosures and stronger governance standards.

A Balasubramanian, Managing Director and CEO, Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC,

said, “We are fully prepared to implement the changes announced by SEBI from April 1.”

Though the move to cut the expense ratio by 15 basis points will impact MF profitability in the short term, the industry believes that the steady inflows and market gains will offset the revenue loss. Brokerage and transaction cost caps have been sharply reduced — from 12 bps to 2 bps for the cash market and from 5 bps to 1 bps for derivatives.

“The volatility in the market may have a marginal impact on SIP inflow, but investors have realised that looking at short-term performance will not help them in wealth creation, particularly when there are no other competing asset classes providing a transparent growth opportunity linked to the country’s economic growth,” Balasubramanian added.

MARKET ACCESS

On the cut in expense ratio of passive funds, Sonam Srivastava, Founder and Fund Manager at Wright Research PMS, said, “Advisors and distributors have little financial incentive to recommend index funds or ETFs because the trail commissions are thin, and this dynamic does not change simply because the expense ratio has been trimmed further.”

Akshat Garg, Head-Research & Product, Choice Wealth, said, “The new thematic fund launch will slow down and will also trigger consolidation. Non-performing or overlapping thematic funds may either be repositioned or merged.”

Sriram BKR, Senior Investment Strategist, Geojit Financial Services, said, “Some AMC’s have overlap in ELSS funds with other diversified funds, but ELSS is witnessing outflows on the backdrop of the new tax regime.”

Fund-raise via IPO hits another high of ₹1.79 lakh crore in FY26

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Despite the recent market upheavals, as many as 112 companies raised a record ₹1.79 lakh crore through mainboard IPOs in the financial year ended March. The mop-up was 10 per cent higher than the previous high of ₹1.62 lakh crore raised by 78 IPOs in the preceding year, according to primedatabase.com.

Pranav Haldea, Managing Director, PRIME Database Group, said it is for the first time in history that there have

been two consecutive years of all-time high IPO fundraising activity.

The gap between the two record-setting fundraising this fiscal would have been high if not for the tepid mobilisation of just ₹18,772 crore in the March quarter, he said. In the past, a strong IPO year almost always was succeeded by a lull lasting two-three years, said Haldea.

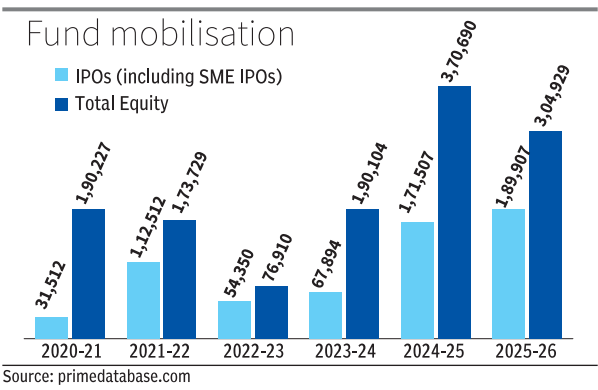
“India’s IPO market is entering FY27 with one of the strongest structural backlogs seen in decades,” said Bhavesh Shah, Managing Director and Head - Investment

Banking, Equirus Capital, adding that he expected capital raise at \$20 billion in the next fiscal year.

“We are continuing to see the pipeline becoming robust with high-quality issuers, with over 150 companies lined up across sectors to raise ₹2.5-₹4 lakh crore. The new financial year will be less about volume and more about quality, scale and pricing discipline,” he added.

MEGA IPOs

Among the IPOs to look forward to are those of the National Stock Exchange and



Mukesh Ambani’s Reliance Jio. The biggest mainboard IPO in FY26 was from Tata

Capital (₹15,512 crore), followed by HDB Financial Services (₹12,500 crore) and LG

Electronics (₹11,605 crore). The average issue size stood at ₹1,598 crore, 23 per cent lower than ₹2,082 crore last year.

Out of 108 IPOs, only 60 (56 per cent) received a mega response of over 10 times, down from 72 per cent in FY25. The average number of applications from retail declined to 12.87 lakh in FY26 from 21.31 lakh last year, with Bharat Coking Coal (68.95 lakh) topping the table, followed by LG Electronics (54.49 lakh) and Meesho (54.12 lakh).

According to Haldea, IPO

Govt plans to list ANRF on Social Stock Exchange

M Ramesh
Chennai

The government intends to list the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) on the Social Stock Exchange (SSE). This is expected to enable the country’s apex institution for funding, coordinating and promoting scientific research across universities, industry and government, to tap into global CSR funds and contributions from the Indian diaspora.

The Foundation is meant to support both fundamental and mission-oriented research work. Under the former, it runs schemes such as the Prime Minister’s Early Career Research Grant (PMECRG), the Advanced Research Grant (ARG), the Inclusivity Research Grant (IRG) and Partnerships for Accelerated Innovation and Research (PAIR). Its mission-mode programmes include Mission for Advancement in High-Impact Areas (MAHA). As of last week, ANRF has provided ₹961.35 crore of funds.

The listing on the SSE is to create “a diversified and sustainable funding base that is less dependent on annual budgetary grants,” notes a recent report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Science and Technology.

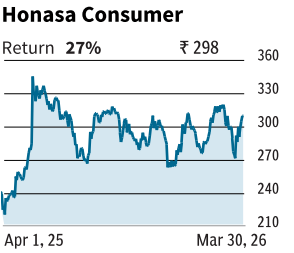
In December 2023, the SGBS Unnati Foundation became the first entity to list on the SSE and raise funds for skill training of underprivileged youth. In 2024, the Swades Foundation raised ₹10 crore.

Writing in World Economic Forum, Sreevas Sahasranamam, Professor at the University of Glasgow, and Jyotsna Sitling, Member, Social Stock Exchange Advisory Committee, SEBI, note, “By ensuring legitimacy with established actors, creating new financial instruments for non-profits, building a cadre of complementary professionals, and standardising KPIs and monitoring, India has set the building blocks in place for converting philanthropy into a regulated, outcome-based marketplace.”

TODAY’S PICK.

Honasa Consumer (₹298.15): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau



The stock has been moving in a sideways range since July last year. The trading range has been broadly between ₹250 and ₹320. Within that, the stock is now moving up from the lower end of range.

The chances are high for the share price to go up towards the upper end of the range in the coming days. Immediate support is in the ₹290-285 region.

We expect Honasa Consumer share price to rise towards ₹320 in the coming days. Traders can buy Honasa Consumer shares now at ₹298. Accumulate on dips at ₹292. Keep the stop-loss

at ₹283. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹302 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹306. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹307 and ₹311 when the price touches ₹310 and ₹314, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹318.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

22330 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
22280	22000	22450	22600	Take fresh shorts only below 22280 with a stop-loss at 22310	
₹735 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
727	710	740	753	Go short now and at 738. Keep the stop-loss at 742	
₹1250 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1240	1215	1265	1295	Take fresh shorts below 1240 with a stop-loss at 1245	
₹288 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
286	282	291	294	Go short on rise at 290. Stop-loss can be kept at 292	
₹284 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
281	279	289	293	Go long only above 289. Stop-loss can be placed at 287	
₹1350 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1335	1300	1365	1380	Take fresh shorts below 1335 with a stop-loss at 1345	
₹981 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
977	968	996	1015	Wait for a rise. Go short at 994 with a stop-loss at 999	
₹2365 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2345	2300	2400	2425	Go short on a break below 2345. Keep the stop-loss at 2355	

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Exit-heavy IPO pipeline runs into valuation resistance as deadlines near

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

A clutch of IPO-bound companies nearing regulatory timelines is running into valuation resistance, as a widening gap between seller expectations and investor appetite complicates listing plans in a softer market. Across several of these upcoming issues, a common factor is the high share of offer-for-sale (OFS), indicating that many IPOs are as much about investor exits as fresh capital raising.

For instance, Continuum Green Energy’s proposed ₹3,650 crore IPO includes an OFS of ₹2,400 crore, nearly two-thirds of the issue, while Veritas Finance’s ₹2,800 crore offering has an OFS component of about ₹2,200 crore (close to 80 per cent). Even Hero FinCorp’s planned issue includes an OFS of roughly ₹1,568 crore



The shift is visible in the unlisted market, which acts as a forward indicator for IPO pricing

(over 40 per cent). Market participants said such structures are becoming a friction point in the current context, where investors are demanding more conservative valuations. “Investors want to come in lower, but existing shareholders are not willing to take that cut. That’s where deals are getting stuck,” said an investment banker.

UNLISTED MARKET

The shift is visible in the unlisted market. Shares of Hero

FinCorp, among the companies with SEBI approval, have corrected sharply in pre-IPO trades, falling to around ₹1,040-1,050 from levels of over ₹2,000 in the past year, per platforms tracking unlisted shares.

Investor behaviour has become more cautious across both primary and unlisted markets, said Vijay Kuppa, CEO, InCred Money. “Investors are approaching the primary market with considerably more discernment in FY26 than they were 12-18 months ago.” What we’re witnessing today is a recalibration of expectations, with investors demanding a more defensible entry point and focusing more on fundamentals, he added.

WAIT OR REPRICE?

Bankers said the current challenge is less about lack of demand and more about pricing, with investors building in a higher margin of safety

amid lower listing gains and market volatility. “The capital is available, but not at any price,” said another banker.

Consequently, companies nearing IPO timelines are increasingly opting to wait rather than reprice issues. “If these deals were to launch today, many would have to revisit pricing. But most promoters would rather wait than reset valuations immediately,” the banker added.

Kamraj Singh Negi, MD and CEO - Investment Banking at Pantomath Capital, said the market is moving towards a “more calibrated approach”, with valuations increasingly linked to fundamentals such as earnings visibility and cash flows. For now, with exit-heavy structures colliding with more cautious investor sentiment, IPO-bound firms face a narrowing set of options: Cut valuations or price back and wait for a more favourable market window.

RBL Bank plans to open 200 branches in FY27

Our Bureau
Mumbai



RBL Bank on Tuesday opened 23 full-service branches in multiple States, taking its network to 603.

The bank plans to open 200 branches in FY27, taking the total branch count to 800-plus. The newly-launched branches are located across Kerala, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand and Gujarat, the bank said.

With an eye on non-resident (NR) business, the bank has opened 13 of the 23 new branches in Kerala, in view of the State’s large NR population and strong remittance-led banking potential.

KEY MILESTONE

R Subramaniam, Managing Director & CEO, RBL Bank, said: “The opening of 23 branches on a single day marks a key milestone in our

growth journey... As we continue to grow, our emphasis remains on leveraging branches as a fulcrum for asset growth through increased branch-led sourcing, building granular liabilities and deepening customer relationships through higher product penetration across geographies.”

On October 18, 2025, the Board of Directors of Emirates NBD Bank (PJSC) and RBL Bank at their respective meetings approved entering into definitive agreements for the former to acquire controlling stake in the latter through a primary infusion of approximately \$3 billion (₹26,850 crore).

GST waiver, tax benefits boost entry-level health cover sizes

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The size of entry-level health insurance covers has increased in the current financial year, largely driven by the waiver of Goods and Services Tax (GST) on premiums and the tax-saving appeal of such policies.

Over the past six months, nearly 15-20 per cent of entry-level health insurance policies have seen an increase in the sum insured, according to industry experts.

“Earlier, a significant proportion of customers tended to opt for entry-level covers in the ₹3-5 lakh range, often viewing health insurance primarily as a compliance or tax-saving tool. Post GST rationalisation, we are increasingly witnessing a decisive shift towards higher sums insured,” Udayan Joshi, Chief Operating Officer, SBI General Insurance, told businessline.

“This trend is now chan-

ging, with a ₹10 lakh cover emerging as the new baseline for entry-level policies,” he added.

POLICY UPGRADES

Insurers are also seeing a noticeable increase in existing policyholders upgrading their coverage, adding riders, or opting for top-up plans to bridge protection gaps. The head of underwriting at a listed private general insurance company said the 18 per cent GST waiver on health insurance premiums (along with life cover) would naturally be more beneficial when the size of the cover, or sum assured, is higher.

“Particularly among those below 35 years of age, there is greater interest not only in taking health cover but also in opting for a higher sum insured,” he said.

STRONG DEMAND

The last two quarters have witnessed strong and sustained momentum in health insurance demand, with GST rationalisation playing



a supporting role.

Improved affordability has lowered entry barriers, encouraging first-time buyers to enter the category and existing policyholders to enhance their protection. “There is an increase in customer preference for higher sum insured amounts, along with emphasis on comprehensive coverage and optional add-ons. The changes brought about by GST exemption in retail health insurance products are also encouraging consumers to opt for higher sums insured due to

poses. Sathya Agencies offers a portfolio of consumer electronics and home appliances with a product range that includes large appliances.

It posted revenues from operations of ₹3,496 crore for the financial year ending March 2025, while profit after tax stood at ₹46 crore.

As of January 31, the company operates 392 consumer electronics retail stores and 35 mobile retail stores across Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala and Karnataka, and one in the Union Territory of Puducherry. It has commercial relationships with electronics and appliance brands such as LG, Blue Star, Daikin, Whirlpool and Haier.

The company has picked Anand Rathi Advisors and Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors are the book running lead managers to the offer.

TAX-SAVING PUSH

As the financial year-end approaches, Section 80D of the Income-Tax Act, 1961, offers individuals an opportunity to review and enhance their health insurance coverage as part of their tax planning.

“The provision allows deductions of up to ₹25,000 for self and family, along with additional tax benefits of up to ₹50,000 for senior citizen parents, making it a meaningful incentive,” said Srikanth Kandikonda, Chief Financial Officer, ManipalCigna Health Insurance.

Rising concerns over the adequacy of health cover are also prompting customers to opt for larger cover sizes.

“Beyond the immediate tax benefit, we recommend using this period as a checkpoint to reassess whether existing health coverage is adequate and aligned with current needs,” he added.

QUICKLY.

Gnani.ai bags \$10 m in Series B round

Mumbai: Bengaluru-based voice-first Agentic AI company Gnani.ai received \$10 million in a Series B investment from Aavishkaar Capital, an impact-focused fund manager, on Tuesday. The capital investment will accelerate Gnani.ai's global expansion, advance its generative AI capabilities, expand multilingual and industry-specific solutions, and strengthen its engineering and product talent base. **OUR BUREAU**

Mesabi Metalics ties up \$520 million credit facility

Mumbai: Mesabi Metalics Company LLC, backed by the Essar Group, has entered into a \$520 million senior secured credit facility with Valor Mining Credit Partners II, LP, a dedicated mining and critical minerals credit fund managed by Breakwall Capital LP (Breakwall) in partnership with Vitrol. With over 750 construction workers currently onsite, the project represents one of the largest private-sector industrial investments. **OUR BUREAU**

Kaynes' ₹3,300-cr chip facility a bridge between Sanand and Silicon Valley: PM

TECH BOOST. It will enhance exports, support India's deeper integration into global semiconductor supply chain

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday formally inaugurated Kaynes Semicon's ₹3,300 crore out-sourced semiconductor assembly and test (OSAT) facility at Sanand in Gujarat, describing it as a "bridge between Sanand and Silicon Valley" and signalling India's deeper integration into the global semiconductor supply chain.

"India's own company Kaynes has become a strong part of the global semiconductor supply chain. It is a proud moment for all Indians," said Modi, while inaugurating the facility that has a capacity to roll out an estimated 60 lakh chips per day once fully operational.

"Today, a new bridge has been formed between Sanand and Silicon Valley. This plant in Sanand will supply intelligent power modules for a company in

California. I am told that a large consignment of the chips made here has been booked for exports. The modules made in Sanand will reach companies in the US and will help power the entire world," he added.

GOVT PUSH

A few months ago, Kaynes Semicon posted on social media that it had already rolled out and shipped 900 Multi-Chip Modules (IPM5), assembled, tested and quality-cleared at the Sanand facility to Alpha & Omega Semiconductor (AOS), US.

The OSAT facility, approved under the India Semiconductor Mission, marks a key milestone in India's push to build domestic chip manufacturing capabilities.

ROLE IN EV ECOSYSTEM

Union IT minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the plant began commercial production within just 14 months, reflecting accelerated execu-



POWERING THE WORLD. PM Narendra Modi inaugurating the Kaynes Project at Sanand on Tuesday. Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel and Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw are also seen

tion in the sector.

The Prime Minister highlighted that the Intelligent Power Modules (IPMs) produced at the Sanand facility will also play a crucial role in supporting India's electric vehicle ecosystem and heavy industries, aligning with the country's broader industrial and energy transition goals.

Modi also pointed to the scale of opportunity in the

technology leadership.

The inauguration marks the third major semiconductor-related development in Sanand as the region rapidly evolves from an automobile hub into a semiconductor manufacturing cluster.

Earlier this year, Modi inaugurated Micron Technology's semiconductor facility in Gujarat, while the pilot plant of CG Semi was also inaugurated last year, further strengthening the region's chip manufacturing ecosystem.

On Tuesday, Indiesemicon Pvt Ltd, a fabless semiconductor and chip design company, signed an MoU with Kaynes Semicon for establishing a framework for the qualification, assembly and testing of QFN40, QFN64 and other mutually agreed semiconductor packages for Indiesemicon's portfolio of ultra-low power and compact System-in-Package modules and SoCs, Indiesemicon said in a release.

sector, noting that India's semiconductor market, currently valued at about \$50 billion, is expected to cross \$100 billion by the end of the decade.

"Our target is to manufacture the maximum number of semiconductor chips in India," he said, adding that ongoing policy reforms and investments are laying the groundwork for long-term

NOP cap to provide relief to ₹; external risks remain

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl.research bureau



The rupee, after slipping to a fresh all-time low of 95.23, recovered to close at 94.81 on Monday. While the domestic markets remained shut on Tuesday, the offshore market indicates some recovery, possibly leading to a gap-up opening on Wednesday. Despite this rebound, the broader trend remains under pressure.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

The immediate trigger for the recovery has been the RBI's move to cap the Net Open Position (NOP-INR) of banks at \$100 million, with compliance mandated by April 10.

In effect, this restricts large dollar positions held by banks, curbing speculative activity. As banks begin to align with the new limits, they are likely to unwind dollar long positions, providing near-term support to the rupee.

However, this is not a structural fix. Geopolitical tensions involving Iran continue to keep risk sentiment fragile, supporting the dollar. At the same time, Brent crude futures remain elevated at around \$107 per barrel, sustaining above the \$100 mark.

With the conflict showing signs of escalation, including the involvement of Yemen-based Houthis, oil prices are expected to stay firm, a negative for the rupee, given India's import dependence.

Foreign flows have also been unfavourable. March recorded net FPI outflows of \$13.6 billion, a sharp reversal from February's inflow of \$4.2 billion.

CHART

On Monday, the rupee rallied sharply and marked an intraday high of 93.48. However, the trend reversed immedi-

ately, leading to an all-time low of 95.23 before wrapping up the session at 94.81.

In case there is a recovery, as indicated by a rally on Tuesday in the offshore market, the rupee could rise to 93.80, a barrier.

If this level is breached, it could move up to 93.40-93.20 in the near-term. That said, the recovery could face challenges in the form of a rising dollar. The dollar index, which gained about 2.8 per cent in March, the biggest monthly gain since July last year, sustains well above 100.

But there is a chance for a corrective move, from the current level of 100.30 to 100. It could extend to 99.40-99.60. If this occurs, along with RBI's measure, the rupee could advance well into the 93.40 level.

However, if the dollar index resumes the rally, the rupee might be stuck in a range since the positive measure by the RBI and the dollar strength is likely to counter balance in the near-term.

OUTLOOK

Overall, the rupee is likely to trade within a narrow band with a mild positive bias in the near term.

The key levels to watch are 93.20 and 94.50. While the RBI's NOP cap may lend support through position unwinding, any sustained recovery will depend on whether the dollar index softens. Otherwise, gains could remain limited.

RoDTEP scheme for exporters extended till September 30

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



BIG RELIEF. The RoDTEP scheme refunds embedded taxes and duties that are not otherwise reimbursed

Extending support to exporters reeling under record freight costs and maritime disruptions linked to the West Asia crisis, the government has decided to continue the popular Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) scheme at fully restored rates for another six months, until September 30.

While exporters welcomed the move as providing immediate relief, there is disappointment over the short extension.

Repeated stop-gap renewals of a key scheme create uncertainty, they said.

"The RoDTEP scheme shall continue for all eligible

export products for another six months... Eligible exports made during the period from April 1, 2026, to September 30, 2026, shall

continue to be entitled to RoDTEP benefit at the rates and value caps in force as on March 31, 2026, subject to the existing terms and conditions of the scheme," per a DGFT notification issued on Tuesday.

WELCOME STEP

The RoDTEP scheme refunds embedded taxes and duties that are not otherwise reimbursed, and is seen as a crucial support mechanism for MSME exporters across many labour-intensive sectors, such as textiles and leather.

The rates range between 0.3 per cent and 3.9 per cent

of the export value linked to the input taxes paid by exporters.

"The continuation of the scheme at this stage is certainly a welcome step as it provides immediate relief and reassurance to exporters. However, exporters require greater policy stability and predictability to plan their operations, pricing and market commitments effectively," Ajay Sahai, Director General, Federation of Indian Export Organisations, told *businessline*.

A longer-term extension of the scheme would go a long way in instilling confidence and ensuring that the

sector is not faced with recurring uncertainty, he said.

RESTORING RATES

The government had slashed the RoDTEP rates by half on February 23, but restored it a month later after exporters warned that the reduced rates would increase costs and affect competitiveness at a time when global demand was slowing down.

While in the April-February 2025-26 period, India's goods exports posted a growth of 1.84 per cent (year-on-year) to \$402.93 billion, in February 2026, exports dipped by 0.8 per cent to \$36.61 billion.

Insta-help model, urban demand drive investor interest in home services

Rohan Das
Chennai

App-based home services companies are seeing increased investor interest, with funding towards the sector having gone up nearly three times between 2023 and 2025.

Per data sourced from Tracxn, online home services companies collectively raised about \$83 million in funding in 2025 against \$64.7 million in 2024 and \$30.5 million in 2023.

The major chunk went to Snabbit and Pronto, who along with Urban Company, make up the online home services market.

Snabbit sought capital thrice in 2025 alone, raising about \$55 million. The company is reportedly expected to raise another \$50-60 million sometime this year.

Pronto, a relatively new entrant, raised about \$40 million in three rounds.

Meanwhile, Urban Company, the largest player in the segment, listed on the bourses last September, raised ₹1,900 crore. The company posted ₹383 crore revenue and a loss after tax of ₹21 crore for Q3 FY26.

Analysts and investors told *businessline* that a shift in consumer behaviour from occasional repair works to frequent, on-demand and instant help, along with increased demand in urban markets, are early signs of profitability and driving investor interest.

NEW BRAND CATEGORY

Rahul Taneja, Partner at Lightspeed, said the home services model had opened up beyond specialised, low frequency tasks like plumbing or carpentry to high fre-



quency tasks such as generalised home cleaning.

He said he believes that this shift is akin to a new brand category and hence has peaked investor interest.

Taneja added that current proceeds are helping incumbent players to "densify demand" across key geographies.

In a recent earnings call, Abhiraj S Bhal, Co-founder and CEO of Urban Company, echoed this. He added that Urban Company will look at offering attractive earnings,

along with other benefits like insurance, to attract and retain the workforce in an increasingly competitive landscape.

The small but rapidly expanding market share of online services in the overall home services sector is also signalling a large headroom for growth.

Rohan Agarwal, Partner at Redseer Strategy Consultants, said despite recent growth, the significant chunk of home services continues to be unorganised and offline. "As of FY2025, online penetration stands at less than 1 per cent of net transaction value but the segment is expanding at a projected CAGR of 18-22 per cent through FY30 as consumers increasingly seek convenience, reliability and accountability that offline alternatives struggle to provide," he said.

How VCMint fast tracks early stage start-up funding

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad



Serial entrepreneur Aditya Vuchi, who built Media Mint with his wife Neelima Marupuru, has identified a lacuna — unavailability of funding for early-stage start-ups — in the start-up investment space.

The couple sold their firm to Everstone Capital after a failed attempt to sell it to a Hyderabad-based digital marketing company.

After exiting the 13-year-old start-up they built in 2010, Aditya founded a venture capital fund, VCMint, using the proceeds from the sale to support early-stage start-ups. In less than two years, the fund invested about ₹40 crore in 60 start-ups.

He said VCMint's investments will cross the ₹100-crore mark over the next two

years, with about half of that capital dedicated to follow-on investments.

FOCUS AREAS

He is keen to back companies that build tailored infrastructure and financial products for gig workers, who currently lack basic dignity despite being the engine of fast commerce. Additionally, there is a focus on digital safety and wellbeing. Given that children are hooked to digital gadgets, he said he would back solutions that provide essential orientation for parents, education for youth and standard operat-

ing procedures for modern households.

For Aditya, building a pipeline of high-potential start-ups is less about aggressive outbound scouting and more about creating a powerful inbound funnel. He has turned LinkedIn into his biggest sourcing engine, actively sharing his insights to attract entrepreneurs who then pitch directly to VC Mint's inbox.

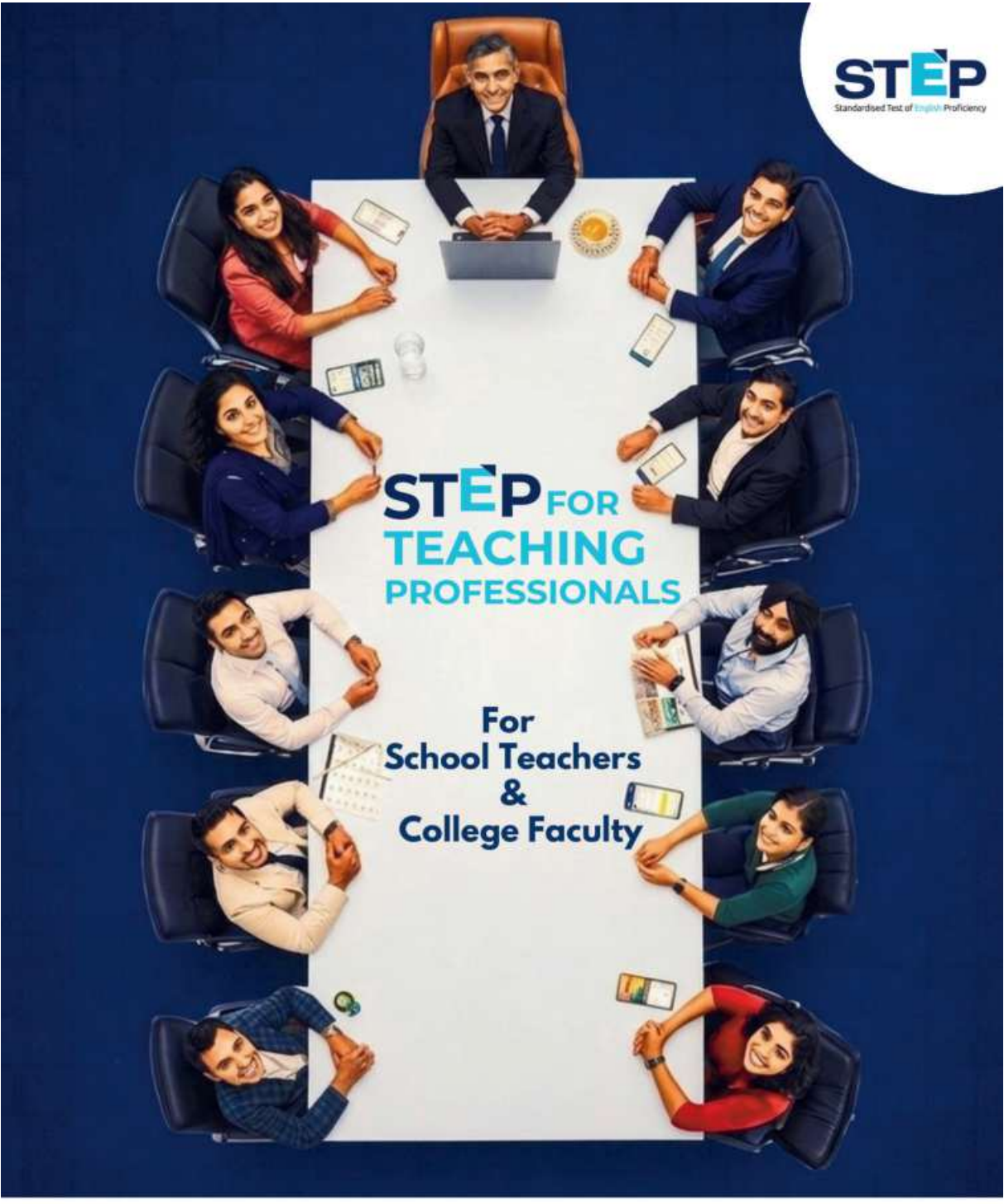
He said he gets leads from his own networks, including hackathons where he finds the right candidates.

"Our ability to identify candidates quickly is a major differentiator. Because we operate with a small team and an informal investment committee, we can move with agility, often writing two to three cheques a month. By staying agile, we ensure founders get the capital they need exactly when they need it most," he said.

"While my angel investing journey began in 2015 by writing small cheques to support founders I personally liked, we have now formalised this into an agile, early-stage investment vehicle. Today, we typically write cheques between \$1,00,000 and \$2,00,000 for companies that have moved past the idea stage and have a product in place," he said.

"Over the past two years, we have maintained a very high investment velocity, backing 60 companies. About 80 per cent of these are in India, and we have built an outsized portfolio in the Hyderabad ecosystem," he said.

"This [the focus on Hyderabad] is not because of a geographic bias; we simply wanted to remove the historical disadvantage Hyderabad start-ups faced, evaluating all companies purely on merit," he said.



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ITR forms notified for AY27, experts advise assessees to scan their books carefully

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Taxpayers can begin filing for the 2026-27 fiscal year this Wednesday, following the Income Tax Department's notification of seven return forms and updated filing procedures.

These forms are for the Assessment Year 2026-27 (previous year or fiscal year 2025-26) and the last set un-

der the Income Tax Act 1961.

ITR-1 is meant for salaried individuals with income up to ₹50 lakh. ITR-2 can be used by individuals with capital gains. ITR-3 is used by assessees having income from business or profession. ITR-4 is for those having income up to ₹50 lakh from business and profession.

ITR-5 is for firms, LLPs, AOPs and BOIs. ITR-6 is used by companies, while

ITR-7 is used by charitable trusts.

Currently, the due date for filing ITR-1 and ITR-2 is July 31, while ITR-3 and ITR-4 for non-audit cases can be filed till August 31. In case of audit required, ITR-3 and ITR-4 can be filed till October 31.

ITR-1 SCOPE WIDENED

According to Sandeep Sehgal, Partner-Tax at AKM Global, taxpayers will con-



Seven return forms have been notified for AY27

tinue with the familiar assessment year-based return structure for AY2026-27,

which should help contain interpretational issues and reduce compliance friction during the current filing window.

Importantly, the scope for ITR-1 has been widened for AY2026-27 by permitting certain taxpayers to report income from up to two house properties, whereas earlier taxpayers with a second house property were required to migrate to ITR-2 or ITR-3.

Now, widening the scope of ITR-1, "helps reduce the compliance burden for taxpayers as they were required to disclose the income of two house properties in ITR-2 or ITR-3," he said.

MISSED RETURNS

Vivek Jalan, Partner at Tax Connect Advisory Services, said ITRs are not filed by many persons who are otherwise eligible to file them. For example, even when the

threshold limit of taxability — ₹4 lakh in the new regime and ₹2.5 lakh in the old regime — is not crossed, a person has to file his ITR if others have deducted a TDS of more than ₹25,000 per annum on his PAN as a deductee, has deposits more than ₹1 crore in current accounts, his foreign travel expenditure is more than ₹2 lakh or electricity bill is more than ₹1 lakh.

"Many persons missed fil-

ing the ITRs consequently and when the Income Tax Department received reports from others regarding the person, then these persons had to face penal action," Jalan said.

"It was noticed that even many ITRs missed filing their ITRs in India when they were liable to do so under these conditions. Now, in ITR-2, 3 and 4, the ITRs require detailed declaration," he said.

NEWSPAPER PUBLIC NOTICE FOR AUCTION OF GOLD JEWELLERY

BAJAJ FINANCE LIMITED
REGISTERED OFFICE: MUMBAI - PUNE ROAD, AKURDI, PUNE - 411035

IT IS HEREBY NOTIFIED BY BFL TO ALL CONCERNED BORROWERS AND THE GENERAL PUBLIC THAT GOLD JEWELLERY PLACED AS SECURITY BY BORROWERS WITH AT THE TIME OF AVAILING GOLD LOAN, IN THEIR RESPECTIVE LOAN ACCOUNTS AND WHO HAVE DEFAULTED IN REPAYMENT OF LOAN AMOUNT OR HAVE FAILED TO PROVIDE THE REQUIRED MARGIN, DESPITE REPEATED NOTICES, WILL BE AUCTIONED ON AN "AS IS WHERE IS" AND "AS IS WHAT IS BASIS". THE BIDDERS ARE REQUESTED TO ADHERE TO THE BELOW TERMS:

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- TO UNDERSTAND THE T&CS AND THEREAFTER DEPOSIT EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT OF ₹ 25,000/- BY WAY OF FUND TRANSFER (NEFT / RTGS/ BAJAJ GOLD AUCTION/PAY) ON OR BEFORE THE DATE OF AUCTION;
- ATTEND IN PERSON AT THE AUCTION VENUE 10AM; AND
- TO CARRY THEIR VALID PROOF OF IDENTITY & ADDRESS AT THE AUCTION VENUE.
- BIDDERS WILL NOT BE ALLOWED TO PARTICIPATE IN AUCTION PROCESS POST 12 NOON ON THE DATE OF AUCTION.
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SCAN ME

(15-05-26); LADNUN - BUS STAND; PKQ6GOL16778234, 16898591, 16998788, 17064602, 17134747, 17224499, 17227356, LILCHHA; PAE7PFI14602759, 14828766, 15739238, 15920132, 16008503, 16117953, 16808638, 16852383, 16894279, 17041625, 17087949, 17372632. LIMBDI - GREEN CHOWK; PKA7GOL17144984, 17286642, 17375342. LUCKNOW - ALAMBHAQ KANPUR ROAD; POV7GOL17263691. LUDHIANA - BGL; PNQ4GOL16862378, 16930050. LUDHIANA - THAN SINGH CHOWK; PDA4GOL17002044, 17365658. LUNAWADA - ST STAND; POGV6GOL15713789, 16849111, 16933602, 16999057, 17062748, 17244190, 17259237. MACHHARA - BGL; PNK6GOL15807655, 17179886, 17323459. MAHENDRAGARH - SDM RESIDENCE ROAD; PG17GOL16852021, 16955172, 17017424, 17286594, 17341956. MAHUDI; PAF3PFI15594052, 15871139, 16775273, 16884899, 17068212, 17082217, 17137592, 17135922, 17220095, 17267585, 17298236. MAHUVA - ANAND DHAN COMPLEX; PBX5GOL16992226, 17262787, 17295618, 17340397, 17378693. MANALI - PARTHASARATHY STREET; PY26GOL17130616. MANAMADURAI - SIVAGANGAI MAIN ROAD; PJ15GOL16770955, 16800362, 17140799. MANDI - DABWALI CHAULTAL ROAD; PBX9GOL16933971, 17090662, 17114084, 17154515, 17286268, 17292014, 17323652. MAUR MANDI - BOHAD WALA CHOWK; PB61GOL17114437, 17213014, 17221813, 17372011. MENPURA; PAF6PFI16823732, 16855436, 16855765, 16895687. METPALLY - MAIN ROAD; PEF7SGL16827551, 16903209, 17046041, 17106488, 17343241. MIRYALAGUDA - BGL; PNT9SGL16768808, 16769778, 16829578, 16823866, 17027416, 17163737, 17214054, 17273420. MODASA - MALPUR ROAD; P31GGOL16851773, 16853961, 17192200, 17291313. MULUGU - GANDHI CHOWK; P3V5SGL17180864, 17241935, 17236109, 17369335. MUNDRA - BHUJ ROAD; P76GGOL17049227, 17136348, 17156112, 17181813. NAGPUR - KAMAL CHOWK; PKA1GOL17020196. NAGPUR - STATION ROAD; PGE9GOL17145625, 17155020, 17226583, 17291358, 17369836. NAGPUR - UNTKHANA ROAD; PF47GOL17318749. NALGONDA - RP ROAD; PNT8SGL16895281. NANDARKHA; PF33PFI14413138. NANDED - TARODA NAKA; PEF9GOL17356409. NANDED - VIP ROAD; PEN3GOL16105330, 16824011, 16953709, 17023933, 17089644, 17120705, 17188362, 17231679, 17212994, 17348558, 17335413. NANDURBAR - PARDESI PURA; PEP6GOL16898720. NARAINGARH - CHANDIGARH ROAD; PPF9GOL17110133, 17341333, 17340957. NARAYANPET - NARSHIREDDY CHOWASTHA; PJH5SGL17217611. NASHIK - BITCO POINT; PC83GOL16922814, 17157891. NASHIK - SHARANPUR ROAD; PGF1GOL16812730, 17047243, 17129896, 17169596, 17322707, 17347742. NASHIK - UPENDRA NAGAR; PLH1GOL16897424, 16925343, 16933100, 16969995, 17014379, 17082385, 17310221. NISSING - KARNAL ROAD; PC72GOL16921616. OSMANABAD - SUNIL PLAZA; PEQ3GOL16934102, 16997912, 17005586, 17020328, 17263660, 17348027, 17368545. PAITHAN - NAKA ROAD; PLQ4GOL17344452. PALANPUR - ABU HIGHWAY ROAD; PEM4GOL16773507, 16898300, 17119132, 17118207, 17119638, 17179346, 17217061, 17331679, 17377133, 17371656. PALWAL - AGRA CHOWK; PMG8GOL17042148, 17120739, 17267779. PANDHARPUR - SAWARKAR CHOWK; PGC9GOL17165387, 17269389, 17370576. PANIPAT - SANOLI ROAD; PBY1GOL16999316. PARBHANI - ANAND NAGAR; PEN4GOL16928279, 17076634. ROORKEE - RAMNAGAR; PPF5GOL17096272. SRIKALAHASTI - MAIN ROAD; PGC6SGL17186040, SRUNGAVARAPUR - KOTA; PBW6SGL16991523, 16992387, 17043819, 17068299, 17235068, 17288785, 17336845. SULLURPETA - PANDU RANGA STREET; PBW7SGL16800110, 16871834, 17115551, 17140859, 17181500, 17176920, 17263326, 17293028, 17324802, 17367783. TADIPATRI - YALLANUR ROAD; PBW8SGL17064199, 17158536, 17287703. TIRUPATI - BAIRAGI PATTEDA; PMB8SGL16861209, 16925275, 16990671. TIRUPATI - KORLAGUNTA; PNB5PFI16884951, 16956187, MATHURA - KRISHNA NAGAR; PLB9SGL16077895, 17105765, 17287828, 17376885. (18-05-26) JABALPUR - WRIGHT TOWN; PGO3GOL16776855, 16900001. KANGRA - DHARAMSHALA ROAD; POR2GOL17238907. KHANDWA - SHIVAJI CHOWK; PCP1GOL17129161. KHARGONE - JAWAHAR MARG; PCJ9GOL17002772. KOTTUR - MAIN ROAD; PLN4SGL17098398, 17235754, 17376091. KUDLIGI - HOSALLI ROAD; PLD9SGL16096442, 16949342, 17315542. KUNIGAL - BM ROAD; PMK8SGL16770867. LAXMANGARH - MURLI MANOHAR MANDIR; PSB6GOL16929958, 16931058, 16968395, 17036892, 17034673, 17181876, 17208768, 17313814. LAXMANGARH RJ; PGM4PRN17271592, 17375622. LINGSUGUR - RAICHUR ROAD; PBZ7SGL13800511, 17238500. LOSAL - DIDWARA ROAD; PGO2GOL17037379. MADANPUR RAMPUR - MAIN ROAD; PLF2SGL16776451, 17116358, 17129600. MADHUGIRI - TVV CIRCLE; PLM7SGL17088525. MAKRAHA - MANGLANA ROAD; PDO9GOL15819951, 15929926, 16936262, 16953238, 16975024, 16996075, 17064225, 17084396, 17298772, 17367889, 17279804. MALLUR - THEATER CIRCLE; PO34SGL17139039. MANENDRAGARH - BGL; PV9SGL17118757, 17220334, 17269426, 17368644. MANPURA MANCHERI; PVB5PFI16884951, 16956187, MATHURA - KRISHNA NAGAR; POF8GOL17019571, 17091377, 17374746. MENAR; PZB7PFI13566474, 17245270. MERTA - CIVIL LINE ROAD; PG91GOL17072046, 17337138, 17336633. MORENA - SHIVNAGAR; PJC8GOL16926991, 17098272, 17178289. NADAUN - BGL; P63FGOL16858565, 17267828. NAGAUR - NAKAS GATE; PLD2GOL17092785. NAGAUR - VIJAY VALLABH CHOWK; PCT6GOL15665099, 16929503, 17018100, 17088465, 17167715, 17168424, 17238126, 17267480, 17263569, 17260483, 17268720, 17326495, 17326251, 17376883, 17379108, 17377912. NAGERCOIL - POLICE STATION ROAD; PEK8SGL17177588. NAI KI THADI; PVB6PFI15755007, 16058269, 17379918. NARSAMPET - JAI SRI THEATER; PCX3SGL16829610, 16946139. NATATA; PVB8PFI16998481. NATHDWARA - NEW ROAD; PAU4GOL16850123, 16951061, 17013852, 17086378, 17232555, 17242929, 17289256, 17322630, 17336355, 17347800. NAWALGARH - JHUNJHUNU ROAD; P79FGOL16833108, 16825303, 16979012, 17044504, 17288838, 17249334, 17271331, 17342821. NAWARANGPUR - PATEL MARG; PCR3SGL16946839, 17023617, 17064266, 17066300, 17248012, 17265447, 17311479, 17367498. NAYAGARH - KHANDAPADA ROAD; PMR9SGL16776547, 17013176, 17012790. NEEM KA THANA - SHAHPURA ROAD; P3V2GOL17320433, 17339783. NIALI - MAIN ROAD; PJD4GOL15863904, 16125265, 16996176, 17015604, 17137962. NILAGIRI - MAIN ROAD; PLO8SGL17094026, 17266559. NIMAPARA - GANESH BAZAR; PJE2SGL17179716, 17333646. NIMBAHERA - UDAIPUR ROAD; POS1GOL16872641, 16880442, 17042539, 17110693, 17109384, 17109374. NIRMAL - GANGA COMPLEX; PCX4SGL16972358, 17004972, 17338588. NIZAMABAD - KAPILA HOTEL ROAD; PB94SGL17187780, 17309506. NIZAMABAD - VINAYAK NAGAR; PCX5SGL16871390, 17215109. NOKHA - BGL; PNZ4GOL16769728, 16945592, 16983747, 17091927, 17157326, 17187188, 17217442, 17215905, 17222262, 17237041, 17273696, 17260614, 17272032, 17273261, 17273988, 17268098, 17290189, 17340015, 17379071. NOKHA - LAHOTI CHOWK; PKD6GOL15622538, 16827229, 17265833, 17286218. NUAPADA - MAIN ROAD; PB8HSGL16893476, 17013069, 17047365, 17287156, 17344499, 17378223, 17369535. PALI - SHIVAJI CIRCLE; PCT7GOL17000224. PAONTASAHIB - MAIN GURUDWARA ROAD; P72GOL16007995, 16800170, 17238157, 17314359. PARKAL - BUS STAND; PJB8SGL16769600, 16946943, 17219212. PARSA GJ; PAF4PFI16945965. PARTUR - MAIN ROAD; PJA7GOL16772623, 16861226. PATTAN - DISTRICT COURT; PC90GOL17224592. PATAUDI - BGL; PNX3GOL16136882, 16881744, 17037188, 17045857, 17136453, 17345520, 17367474. PATRAN - JAKHAL ROAD; PB59GOL16776760, 16798738, 17112121, 17160381, 17185195, 17261287. PEDDAPALLE - SUBASH NAGAR; PEO3SGL17065790, 17315726. PEHOWA - AMBALA ROAD; PEM5GOL16953849, 17270438. PHILLAUR - BGL; PNK7GOL16934731, 16992998. PIMPALGAON - CHINCHKOTHI ROAD; PCQ1GOL17073115, 17072927. PINJORE - KALAKA ROAD; POQ5GOL16896055, 16921215, 17068712, 17214784, 17257649. PITHORAGARH - BGL; PNZ3GOL17074439, 17215445, 17288813. PORBANDAR - MG ROAD; P51JGOL16832534, 16922562, 16941022, 16940545, 17135391, 17190642, 17220187, 17262318, 17263418, 17296126, 17323106. PORBANDAR - SVP ROAD; PB95GOL13782288, 15668818, 16994332, 17178647, 17242289, 17349825, 17383006. PORSA - BGL; POA4GOL17223572, 17323427. PUDUKKOTTAI - EAST MAIN STREET; PEP1SGL16896152, 17108841, 17287513. PUNDRI - KARNAL ROAD; PGP4GOL16990893, 17210922. PUNE - BHOSARI; PZB2GOL16980838, 17173303. PUNE - CHANDANNAGAR; PZB1GOL17276745, 17277503. PUNE - CHINCHWAD; PAN8GOL16891636. PUNE - DANGE CHOWK; PKH6GOL16770584. PUNE - DEHU ROAD; PJA9GOL17087503. PUNE - GHORPADI BT KAWADE ROAD; PMW5GOL17136145. PUNE - HADAPSAR; PAN9GOL15637396, 15890494, 16885547, 17013198, 17313111. PUNE - KATRAJ; PED9GOL17039328, 17074293. PUNE - KONDHWA; PMV7GOL16834947. PUNE - PIMPRI SHAGUN CHOWK; PLX1GOL17135643, 17345625. PUNE - SAMBHAJI NAGAR; PLV4GOL16877615, 17249017, 17373955. RAJKOT - GONDAL ROAD; PB80GOL17239584, 17347303. RAJKOT - KOTHARIYA ROAD; PF29GOL16905908, 17212759, 17297762. RAJKOT - MAVDI ROAD; PB13GOL16877400, 17337742. RAJKOT - ONE FIFTY FEET RING ROAD; PGJ1GOL17247944, 17288492, 17287029. RAJAPURA - CALIBER MARKET; P810GOL17368302. RAJULA - JAFFRABAD ROAD; P7Q0GOL16868580, 16946309, 17022201, 17045476, 17065798, 17054412, 17210627, 17239388, 17242716, 17369475. RAMPURA PHUL - BANK BAZAR; PCS2GOL17208722, 17320290. RANIA - SIRSA ROAD; PGJ2GOL15697864, 16777072, 17037635, 17086822, 17082955, 17120564, 17139935, 17296191, 17317318, 17319023, 17337880, 17337407, 17370132. RANPUR - BUS STAND ROAD; PIX9GOL17021145. RAPAR - COURT ROAD; PF22GOL17101375. SAMAKHIALI - NEW BUS STAND; PC48GOL17215871. SHOOLAGIRI - HOSUR ROAD; PKC5SGL15694054, 17336580. VIJAYAWADA - BHAVANIPURAM; PMBSGL17065742. VIJAYAWADA - CHITTI NAGAR; PMBS3SGL17215087, 17494006, 17266654, 17315019. VIJAYAWADA - ELURU ROAD; PMB2SGL17119368. VIJAYAWADA - IBRAHIMPATNAM; PMB6SGL16870110, 16935465, 17016497, 17019145, 17083686. VIJAYAWADA - MOGHALRAJPURAM; PGA8SGL17051474, 17050811, 17065509. VIJAYAWADA - SATYANARAYANPURAM; PMB4SGL17208852. VIZAG - DWARAKANAGAR; PIS2SGL16836468, 17096003, 17158003. (19-05-26) MYSORE - NARAYANA SHASTRI ROAD; PGH8SGL16936858, 16991346, 17326229. MYSORE - VIVEKANANDA NAGER; PED7SGL1677511, 17377737. NANJANGUD - MGS ROAD; PB29SGL16834219, 17090509, 17223799, 17335877. NARASINGHPUR - BGL; PNT1GOL17048156, 17133284, 17309685, 17368218, 17368998. PATTAMUNDRI - MAIN ROAD; POH6SGL17322493, 17379173. PHALODI - NAGAUR ROAD; PG19GOL15743517, 16781272, 16953742, 16999089, 17048954, 17094712, 17112081, 17161547, 17177354, 17190348, 17241484, 17265760, 17298712, 17377224. PHALSUND; PGS4PRN16860549, 16958499, 17185536. PHULBANI - BGL; P93ASGL15637808, 15664891, 15734885, 15782735, 15800446, 15799652, 16798447, 16874736, 16873790, 16897602, 16980223, 16974690, 17136619, 17137080, 17321379. PILANI - VIDHYA VIHAR; PNK1GOL16830481, 16899575, 17261043, 17314265. PILIBANGA - GENRAL MARKET ROAD; P101GOL16856072, 16980969, 16998073, 17043151, 17088377, 17137230, 17164674, 17163496, 17185965, 17219444, 17294681. PIPAR - RAILWAY STATION ROAD; PNN6GOL16781968, 16809767, 16969954, 17006121, 17066863, 17075297, 17094655, 17250765, 17319587, 17373194. PIPILI - HATA CHOWK; PGE1SGL16778139, 17187703. PUNE - WAGHOLI; PJA4GOL16046944, 16857409. PUNE - WARJE; PKO2GOL16821308, 17089846. PURI - KONARK ROAD; POG3SGL17097558, 1718382, 17243041. RAEBARELI - KACHEHARI ROAD; POU1GOL17372443. RAGHUNATHPUR - GOPALPUR; POF6SGL17108989, 17238344, 17262845. RAHURI - BUS STAND ROAD; POY2GOL17265696, 17346911. RAICHUR - GUNJ MAIN ROAD; PEP2SGL17017432. RAIGARH - JAGATHPUR; PL16GOL17022804, 17137471, 17138272, 17186665. RAIPUR - PACHPEDINAKA; PL19GOL16995607, 17078283. RAISINGHNAGAR - PANCHHYAT SAMATI ROAD; PE15GOL16927075, 17068209, 17329404, 17267379. RAJGANGPUR - MAIN ROAD; PNV9SGL16797761, 16830941, 17371832. RAJGARH - SADULPUR; PKC2GOL16852748, 17048725. RAJGURUNAGAR - PUNE NASHIK HIGHWAY; PCQ2GOL17001863, 17014099, 17074762, 17136092, 17134241, 17378311, 17378220. RAJNAGAR - MAIN ROAD; PLJ3SGL15801294, 15802200, 15983663, 16102064, 16946597, 17044737, 17069628, 17066960, 17086457, 17248942, 17344322. RAJSAMAND - JAL CHAKKI CHOURAHA; PCT8GOL16849721, 16990443, 17218063, 17297321, 17382334. RAMANAGARA - RAILWAY STATION ROAD; PEH1SGL15644532, 17219048. RAMGANJ - MANDI; PF24GOL15773911, 16796562, 16953609, 16968455, 17016867, 17239192, 17266581, 17368955. RANEBENNUR - PB ROAD; PG15SGL16797481, 16853938, 17014014, 17343786. RATANGARH - LINK ROAD; PEF6GOL16880457, 16991225, 17092878. RATIA - SANJAY GANDHI CHOWK; PIY9GOL16775727, 16953760, 17017005, 17109786, 17107554, 17260859, 17287341, 17311813. RATNAGIRI - MAZGAON ROAD; PFG2GOL17156712, 17374769. RAVATBHATA - BGL; PSV2GOL16785849, 17047984, 17087313, 17380029. REWA - BGL; PNR9GOL16827448, 17240440. REWARI - BRASS MARKET; PIZ3GOL16829814, 17219761. ROHA - ST STAND COMPLEX; PCQ3GOL16897111, 17084254, 1737493, 17324257. ROHRU - BGL; POA2GOL16799174, 17041551, 17065866, 17067749, 17084957, 17109900, 17157110, 17213973, 17221797, 17239476. ROHTAK - KATH MANDI; PIY5GOL16893514, 16979480, 17136342. ROORKEE - GANESHPUR; POR4GOL17220728, 17317904. ROPAR - BELA ROAD; PB30GOL16799472, 17073805, 17300401. SAFIDON - RAILWAY ROAD; PIY3GOL16950615, 17015143, 17269570, 17346731, 17366051. SALUMBABA - BGL; PNV7GOL16803407, 16984163, 17020845, 17139002, 17411133, 17140428, 17188578, 17250171. SAMANA - MAIN ROAD; PEX3GOL16957318, 17296833. SANGAMNER - NAVIN NAGAR ROAD; PEN7GOL16996398, 17094997, 17134346, 17269153. SANGAREDDY - BGL; P4D3SGL15698395, 16850030, 17088693. SANGARIA - GURUDAWARA ROAD; PF30GOL16049595, 16775776, 16970694, 17262693, 17264552, 17337136, 17375980.

QUICKLY.

Cocoa surges, raw sugar loses ground



London: Cocoa futures rose sharply on Tuesday, while raw sugar prices slipped from the previous session's five-month high. London cocoa rose 5.1 per cent to £2,479 a tonne by 1347 GMT. New York cocoa gained 5.2 per cent to \$3,319. Raw sugar fell 0.6 per cent to 15.45 cents per lb, while white sugar lost 1 per cent to \$447.70 a tonne. **REUTERS**

Crude oil adds to record monthly gains

London: Brent oil futures were closing out their largest monthly gain in history with another lurch higher after a fresh tanker attack in the Middle East and a warning from the US Defence Secretary. Brent crude futures for May were up \$5.31 at \$118.09 per barrel at 1326 GMT. US WTI futures for May were up 49 cents at \$103.37 at 1326 GMT. **REUTERS**

Aluminium near 4-year peak on supply concerns



London: Aluminium rose on Tuesday, balancing near four-year highs and heading for the biggest monthly gain since 2018, due to fears of a prolonged supply squeeze after Iranian strikes damaged key Gulf smelters. Benchmark three-month aluminium on the LME rose 3.1 per cent to \$3,505 a tonne. **REUTERS**

More global investors exited gold ETFs in March

NET EXODUS. \$2.34 outflow for every \$1 inflow on fears of inflation, interest rate hikes, dollar strength and banks offloading the yellow metal's reserves

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

For every dollar that flowed into physically-backed gold exchange-traded funds (ETFs) in March, there was an outflow of \$2.3, according to data from the World Gold Council (WGC).

According to the data, while investments in gold ETFs totalled \$9.12 billion, investors chose to cash in \$21.35 billion. Overall, gold ETFs witnessed more outflows in all four weeks of the month.

While outflows were the second-highest in the week ending March 28, the inflows lagged behind those of the first two weeks.

Gold has been at the receiving end since the US-Israel axis launched an offensive against Iran on February 27.

Interestingly, outflows

were witnessed across the world in the fourth week compared to the earlier three weeks, when Asia bucked the trend to be positive.

In the fourth week, exits from ETFs in Asia almost matched North America.

In the fourth week, North America saw the flight of \$1.58 billion, Europe \$1.15 billion, Asia \$1.52 billion and others \$0.06 billion.

DOWN 15% IN A MONTH

Over the past month, gold prices have declined by 15 per cent.

The precious metal has shed over 19 per cent after it peaked at \$5,608 an ounce on January 30.

It is currently ruling at \$4,600 an ounce. On the COMEX, June gold contracts are quoted at \$4,632 an ounce.

Soaring crude oil prices, strengthening of the dollar, concerns over global infla-



ETFs investments from Jan 1-March 28, 2026

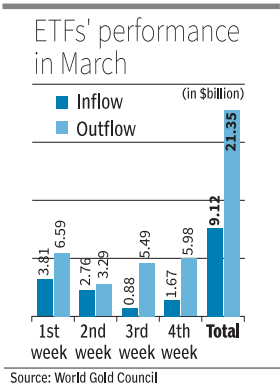
	AUM* (in \$b)	Fund flows (in \$b)	Holdings (in tonnes)	Demand (in tonnes)
North America	301.8	-1.25	2,084.10	-11.11
Europe	204.0	-0.40	1,408.60	-10.70
Asia	75.2	13.28	516.60	78.50
Others	10.8	0.28	74.60	1.40
Total	591.8	11.94	40,839.00	58.10

Source: World Gold Council * Assets under management

tion that could force banks to hike interest rates and fears of banks selling gold reserves have dragged the precious

metal lower soon after the Iran war broke out.

US research agency BMI, an unit of Fitch Solutions,



Source: World Gold Council

said it expects gold to remain under pressure in the second quarter and beyond. Hawkish US Fed sentiment and dollar strength will further dampen gold's attractiveness.

PRICE FORECAST

However, BMI said it was maintaining its 2026 gold price forecast at an annual average of \$4,600/oz. It expects prices to remain under

Govt extends zero duty import of tur, urad; retains 30% levy on yellow peas

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The Union government has extended the import policy for key pulses, such as tur, urad and yellow peas, by another year till March 31, 2027, to ensure adequate supplies.

Black matpe (urad) and pigeon pea (tur) imports will continue to remain duty-free, while yellow peas will continue to attract an import duty of 30 per cent. The current import policy for tur, urad and yellow peas ended on Tuesday.

"It's a good decision by the government to extend the import policy for another year as it will provide long

term visibility for the industry," said Bimal Kothari, Chairman, India Pulses and Grains Association.

DGFT NOTIFICATION

Kothari said with this policy extension, the pulses import volumes are likely to be over 5 million tonnes (mt) during 2026-27, similar to the current year's volumes.

Pulses import volumes are seen reducing to around 5.23 mt this fiscal from 7.3 mt a year ago, he said.

The DGFT, in separate notifications, said the free import policy of tur and urad stands extended up to March 31, 2027.

"Import of yellow peas is free without the MIP (minimum import price) condi-

tion and without port restriction, subject to the registration under online import monitoring with immediate effect, for all import consignments where Bill of lading is issue on or before March 31, 2027," it said.

The pulses trade was expecting the government to maintain a *status quo* on the current import policy for tur and urad amidst concerns of the emergence of El Nino, which may bring in lower-than-normal rain impacting the production of key kharif pulses.

Besides, the ongoing war in West Asia has disrupted the supply chain resulting in higher freight and insurance costs, and in likely higher imports.

Natural rubber zooms to ₹221/kg on tight supply, global cues

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Natural rubber prices continued their upward trend, touching ₹221 per kg in the Kottayam market on Monday, driven by a mix of domestic and global factors.

Traders point to tightening supply conditions, extreme temperatures in key rubber-growing regions, fluctuations in crude oil prices and a sharp rise in international rubber prices — up about ₹25 per kg in Bangkok — as key reasons behind the surge.

George Vally, President of the Indian Rubber Dealers



Federation, said that ongoing tensions in West Asia were adding to the concerns.

Any escalation could disrupt the supply of critical imported inputs, such as chemicals and synthetic rubber, used by the consuming industry.

pressure as the year progresses and the US-Iran war drags on.

A look at the year-to-date data of WGC shows that gold is probably being held by Asian investors, particularly in India and China.

As of March 28, inflows into gold ETFs exceeded \$52.13 billion and outflows were \$40.17 billion.

In North America and Europe, there was a net outflow of \$1.23 billion and \$0.40 billion, respectively. However, Asia has seen a net inflow of \$13.29 billion, supporting gold prices.

CHINA, INDIA POSITIVE

Data show that China and India are the top investors in gold ETFs so far this year.

Chinese investments in the ETFs were \$7.93 billion, while in India, they were \$3.13 billion. Japanese inflows were also positive at \$1.02 billion.

However, in the fourth week, Chinese investors chose to exit ETFs, with the outflow at \$1.54 billion. Details of Indian investments were not available.

Investors in France encashed \$0.19 billion, Canadians and Australians took away \$0.05 billion each and Germans \$0.03 billion.

In terms of tonnage, the US and China witnessed a 10 per cent drop, while it was a 6.8 per cent decline in the UK, where the outflow was almost \$1 billion.

Nippon India ETF Gold BeES was among the top 10 global ETFs that witnessed inflows.

BMI said among institutions, the Central Bank of Turkey sold 58-60 tonnes of gold (approximately \$8 billion) over two weeks in March 2026, and Russia sold 15-15.5 tonnes of the precious metal over January and February 2026.

tions to shipping routes and supply chains for key inputs, such as chemicals, petrochemical derivatives and synthetic rubber.

Santhosh Kumar, CEO of Harrison's Malayalam Ltd, said the West Asia tensions and the resultant socio-economic fallout weighed on the commodities trade, including for rubber.

Coupled with these, the ongoing lean season had sharply reduced natural rubber output, triggering a short-term price spike.

The situation may take time to stabilise, with supply constraints likely to keep natural rubber prices firm in the near term, he added.

IMD forecasts more heatwave days in May-June compared to a cooler April

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) announced on Tuesday that while April daytime temperatures will be normal or below normal across much of the country, parts of East, North-East and North-West India, along with the Southern Peninsula, should expect above-normal heat.

Releasing the weather forecast for three months of the summer season (April-June), IMD's Director-General M Mohapatra said: "Maximum temperatures are likely to be normal to below normal over many parts of the country except most parts of East and North-East India, as well as eastern parts of central India and adjoining peninsular regions, where above-normal maximum temperatures are expected. Also, above-normal



RAIN VS RISK. While April rainfall may exceed normal levels, heat stress could impact key crops

minimum temperatures are likely over most parts of the country, except some regions of Maharashtra and Telangana." He added that the IMD would issue its first monsoon forecast for 2026 after two weeks.

HEATWAVE DAYS

He also said above-normal numbers of heatwave days are likely in parts of East, Central and North-West India, and the South-East peninsula during the April-June period.

In the monthly forecast for April, IMD said above-normal heatwave days are likely over many parts of the coastal areas of Odisha, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Andhra Pradesh, and in isolated regions of Gujarat, Maharashtra and Karnataka. There may be two more extra heatwave days in these areas, beyond the normal three-five days, Mohapatra added.

He said that rainfall during April is most likely to be above normal, or more than

112 per cent of the long period average (LPA) of 39.2 mm.

KEY CROPS MAY BE HIT

The IMD said that significant heat stress during the reproductive stages of Boro rice, maize, green gram, black gram and vegetables may lead to poor grain setting, flower drop and reduced yields. Accelerated maturity of late-sown wheat, chickpea and lentil may result in reduced grain filling duration and reduced yield in East and East-Central India and the adjoining peninsular regions, it said in a statement.

Further, terminal heat stress in late-sown wheat, mustard and barley could cause reduced yield in North-West India.

The IMD also predicted reduced pod filling and grain formation in crops, along with increased flower and fruit drop in mango and banana.

El Nino to emerge around Aug, says Australian Met body

Srikrishnan PC
Chennai

La Nina has ended, but the drought-bearing El Nino may emerge towards the end of the Southern Hemisphere winter (August), the Australian Bureau of Meteorology (BoM) has said.

The bureau said in its Southern Hemisphere monitoring report that oceanic and atmospheric indicators of the El Nino-Southern Oscillation (ENSO) are currently in a neutral state.

All models, including BoM's, are forecasting the tropical Pacific to continue warming in the coming months. Neutral ENSO conditions are expected to persist until at least late autumn (March-May), with all models indicating warming to levels consistent with El Nino by the end of winter (August).

Some models show that El Nino thresholds could be

reached as early as May, while others show that the warming will be slower and the thresholds won't be met until late winter.

For an El Nino state to last, the ocean and the atmosphere must work together to strengthen each other, said BoM.

In the past, El Nino events have led to either a late arrival of the South-West monsoon or deficient rain, besides prolonged dry spells. However, before El Nino emerges, India could receive above-normal rainfall.

The report said that the sea surface temperatures (SSTs) in the central tropical Pacific have been in the ENSO-neutral range (-0.80 to +0.80 °C) for the past six weeks. The most recent relative Nino-3.4 index value for the week ending March 29 was -0.42°C. A recent pulse of warming in the sub-surface suggests further warming of SSTs is likely in the coming weeks.

IMD OUTLOOK

Meanwhile, the India Meteorological Department said in its biweekly report that weak La Nina conditions persisted. Sea surface temperatures in the east-central and eastern equatorial Pacific were still below normal.

The Monsoon Mission Climate Forecast System (MMCFS) says the switch to ENSO-neutral is most likely to occur between February and April 2026 and thereafter.

TRADE SIGNALS

The BoM report added that atmospheric indicators, such as trade winds, pressure and cloud patterns, in the tropical Pacific reflect ENSO-neutral conditions. Westerly wind anomalies have extended into the central equatorial Pacific in the last fortnight and are forecast to persist in the coming weeks. This would also act to enhance warming of tropical Pacific SSTs.

AIRIA to host 12th edition of rubber expo from April 7 to 10

Our Bureau
Kochi

The All India Rubber Industries Association (AIRIA) will host the 12th edition of the India Rubber Expo 2026 (IRE 2026) from April 7-10 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

The four-day event is expected to attract over 400 exhibitors and nearly 45,000 trade visitors from around 14 countries.

Industry stakeholders will converge to showcase innovations, explore partnerships, and assess emerging market trends.

NEW OPPORTUNITIES

The event will run alongside the International Rubber Conference (IRC) from

April 7-9. AIRIA conducted roadshows across key cities, including Delhi, Kolkata, Chennai, Pune and Ahmedabad to boost participation, said a press release.

Chairman of IRE 2026 Vipin Mehta said the expo aimed to spotlight new opportunities within India's rapidly evolving rubber sector.

Chief Convenor Sanjeev Sikka said, "With participation from over 14 countries and strong representation from key markets like China, the expo highlights India's rise as a premier destination for sourcing and manufacturing."

AIRIA President Anay Gupta said the upcoming edition will bring together leading players and experts from across the value chain.

Amid low demand, Centre cuts sugar allocation for April

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The Union government has allocated 23 lakh tonnes (lt) of sugar for sales in the domestic market during April, which is lower from 23.5 lt a year ago. It is also lower than the 25 lt allocated in April 2024. Taking the allocation as actual consumption data, though there is a marginal variation in the number for the year, sugar demand for the first seven months of the 2025-26 season (October-September) has been pegged at 156 lt against 161 lt a year ago, an estimated fall of 3 per cent.

For April 2023, the government initially released 22 lt and after a few days allocated an additional 2 lt.

Sources said if there is

need, the government ctykd always allocate additional quota.

According to the monthly release order issued by the Food Ministry, mills in Maharashtra have been allocated 8.17 lt for April 2026 against 8.05 lt a year ago. For units in Uttar Pradesh, it is 7.83 lt against 8.38 lt and in Karnataka 3.3 lt against 3.24 lt.

NORMS EASED

Following representations from sugar mill associations, the Centre relaxed monthly dispatch norms for March 2026, citing weak demand and lower sales. Any shortfall from the quota will not be treated as a violation, but the relief is strictly one-time.

Under existing rules, mills must dispatch at least 90% of their monthly quota or face



LESS SWEETER. The volume allocated for sale is lower than a year ago and also less than the quota permitted in April 2024

penalties via cuts in subsequent allocations. The Food Ministry had fixed a March 2026 quota of 22.5 lt.

"Except December and February this season when the quota was at par with a year ago, in all other months, the allocation has been lower. When last season's allocation was cut by over 5 per

cent to 275.5 lt, it was said that the base was high due to the 2024 elections. Now, with such a low base, if sugar consumption is not rising, the industry needs to brainstorm the reasons," said an industry expert.

NEW MODALITIES

The Ministry also said that

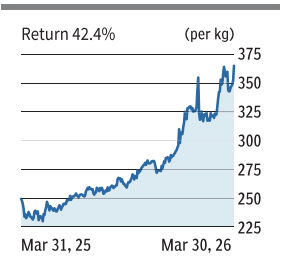
new modalities had been issued against non-compliant sugar mills for violating the monthly quota, effective April 1. It has been decided to deduct the release quota for April 2026 on the basis of the excess quantity of sugar sold, and less utilisation of sugar during January will be deducted from the release quota for April 2026.

Also, failure to submit the monthly P-II for March through API modules by April 10 will lead to no quota for May.

All sugar mills have also been directed to ensure compliance of mandatory packaging of 20 per cent of sugar in jute bags under the Jute Packaging Material (Compulsory Use in Packing Commodities) Act, 1987, and submit the information on the NSWSP portal.

COMMODITY CALL.

Buy aluminium futures once the price breaks out of ₹356



Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Aluminium futures, which saw a decline recently, found support early last week and have moved up since then. The April futures, now trading at ₹350 per kg, bounced off the support at ₹325 last week.

The broader trend is positive, and the recovery is backed by good momentum. Therefore, further rally from the current level is highly likely to happen.

Nevertheless, there is a hurdle ahead at ₹356. That said, any drop in price on the back of this is likely to be short-lived.

Eventually, aluminium futures could surpass ₹356 and move towards ₹380 in the near-term.

On the other hand, if the contract declines below ₹330, the near-term outlook could turn negative.

In such a scenario, aluminium futures could drop to ₹315 and ₹300.

Overall, the bias is bullish, and we expect the contract to break out of ₹356.

TRADE STRATEGY

Buy aluminium futures once they break out of ₹356. Target and stop-loss can be ₹380 and ₹344, respectively.

If the contract sees a price moderation, traders can buy at ₹340. Place initial stop-loss at ₹325.

When the contract breaks out of ₹356, revise the stop-loss to ₹344. Exit at ₹380.

QUICKLY.

Granules Life Sciences' facility gets USFDA nod

Hyderabad: The US Food and Drug Administration (USFDA) has concluded its inspection of the manufacturing facility of Granules Life Sciences, a subsidiary of Granules India, at Shameerpet, with a classification of voluntary action indicated, the company said. **OUR BUREAU**

IHC invests \$1 b for 41.5% stake in Sammaan Capital

Bengaluru: Sammaan Capital has received a capital infusion from West Asia-based International Holding Company (IHC), which is set to acquire a controlling stake in the company through a transaction valued at \$1 billion. The firm said IHC, through its affiliate Avenir Investment, will become the promoter of Sammaan by acquiring a 41.5 per cent stake via a preferential allotment of shares and warrants. **OUR BUREAU**

Novo Nordisk cuts starting price of Ozempic by 36%, Wegovy by 48%

SECOND ROUND. Move comes a week after generics launched their versions at 50-80 per cent less

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Danish healthcare major Novo Nordisk has slashed prices for a second time in India of its blockbuster obesity drug Wegovy, besides dropping prices on its diabetes product Ozempic as well. The move comes a little over a week after a patent on semaglutide (the active ingredient in Ozempic and Wegovy) expired in markets, including India. Come April 1, the price of the starting dose of Ozempic will be reduced by 36 per cent, while that of Wegovy will be reduced by 48 per cent in India, the company said. There is also an average

Price war			
	Old weekly price	New weekly price	(INR incl taxes) New monthly price
Ozempic®			
Ozempic® FLXT 0.25mg	2,200.00	1,415.00	5,660.00
Ozempic® FLXT 0.5mg	2,542.50	2,025.00	8,100.00
Ozempic® FLXT 1mg	2,793.75	2,275.00	9,100.00
Wegovy®			
Wegovy® FLXT 0.25mg	2,712.00	1,415.00	5660.00
Wegovy® FLXT 0.5mg	3,462.00	2,025.00	8,100.00
Wegovy® FLXT 1mg	3,462.00	2,275.00	9,100.00
Wegovy® FLXT 1.7mg	4,100.00	3,187.50	12,750.00
Wegovy® FLXT 2.4mg	4,100.00	4,100.00	16,400.00

The new prices in India for Ozempic® and Wegovy® across dosages effective April 1, 2026.

price reduction of 23.8 per cent for Ozempic and 27 per cent for Wegovy across doses, it added.

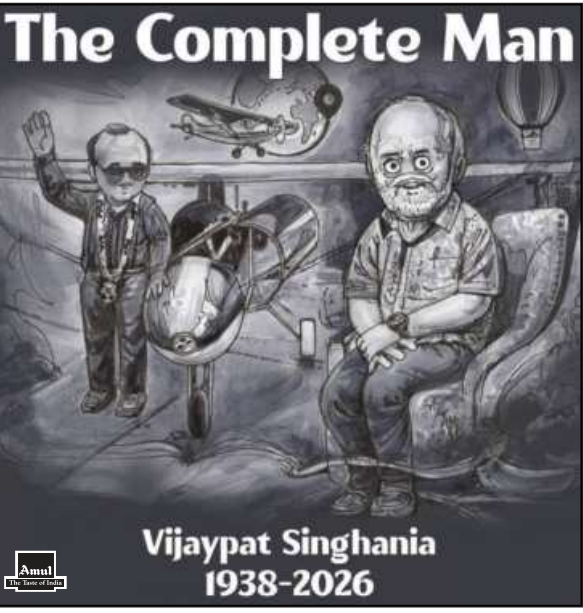
cut has been higher than expectations,” a doctor told *businessline*. The GLP-1 segment (the class to which this product belongs) has seen much activity since semaglutide went off patent protection on March 20. Several drug-

makers, including Natco, Glenmark, Sun Pharma and Dr Reddy's Laboratories, for instance, launched generic versions at prices between 50 and 80 per cent less than the innovator price.

WIN-WIN SITUATION But a price-cut from the innovator in seven days from patent-expiry sets a new precedent in terms of “proactively expanding excess”, instead of resisting the entry of generics, observed diabetologist Rajiv Kovil. When the entry level price of the innovator is low and the difference is not much from the generic's price, “that's a win-win for the patient,” he said. The products are prescription-only drugs, and the In-

dian drug regulatory authority had cautioned companies against misleading promotions. Doctors have also stressed the importance of “patient selection” (understanding their medical history), besides red-flagging adverse events — stomach-related problems, gastritis, pancreatitis and loss of vision, for example.

PRICE CUTS The starting doses of Ozempic (0.25 mg) and Wegovy (0.25 mg) in India will now be at a daily price of ₹202 or a weekly price of ₹1,415, inclusive of taxes, Novo said. Last November, the company had taken a 37 per cent price cut on its starting dose of Wegovy.



Pricey memory chips hit smartphone sales in 2026

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Smartphone sales declined nine per cent on-year basis due to rising memory component costs coupled with seasonal softness, as per Counterpoint Research's India Weekly Smartphone Sell-out Tracker. By the ninth week of 2026, over eight brands had increased prices at an average hike of ₹1,500. Despite the impact on consumer footfalls and overall sales, this hike is expected to rise further. New product launches are also being introduced at higher price points.

TEMPORARY BOOST Even Republic Day sales succeeded in providing only a temporary boost, primarily in the online channel. Sustained premiumisation continued to maintain value growth. “India's smartphone market started the year on a low note as persistent price increases continued to weigh on consumer demand. Limited promotional intensity

and fewer new launches further impacted purchase momentum. All this resulted in weaker retail conversions across channels, reflecting guarded consumer sentiment,” said Prachir Singh, Senior Research Analyst, Counterpoint Research. Vivo recorded the strongest annual sales growth at 19 per cent in the first nine weeks of 2026, owing to new launches and performance of the Y and T series. Apple grew 12 per cent, led by discounts and sustained demand for its iPhone 17 series. “Ongoing global uncertainties, including geopolitical tensions and rising essential commodity prices, are expected to continue to weigh on discretionary spending, with India's smartphone market projected to decline by around 10 per cent in 2026. While premium segments are expected to remain resilient, affordability constraints will continue to impact demand in the mass segment, leading to a gradual and uneven recovery,” said Tarun Pathak, Research Director, Counterpoint Research.

IndiGo names aviation veteran William Walsh as CEO

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

InterGlobe Aviation (IndiGo) has named aviation veteran William Walsh as Chief Executive Officer (CEO), subject to regulatory approvals. The appointment, announced on Tuesday, brings in a seasoned industry leader as the airline navigates its next phase of expansion. Walsh, currently Director General of the International Air Transport Association (IATA), will step down on July 31, 2026, and is expected to take charge by August 3. Popularly known as Willie, Walsh had previously served as CEO of British Airways and International Airlines Group (IAG), which owns

airlines including Aer Lingus, British Airways, Iberia, Level and Vueling. Widely regarded as an influential figure in modern aviation, Walsh began his career as a pilot before rising to leadership roles, including Chief Operating Officer and CEO of Aer Lingus from 2000 to 2005. He later led British Airways from 2005 to 2011 and IAG from 2011 to 2020, before taking over at IATA. **FOCUS ON STRATEGY** In his new role, Walsh will oversee the airline's overall management and strategic direction, focusing on strengthening operational performance, advancing network and commercial strategy, and enhancing customer experience.



William Walsh

well-positioned to be at the forefront of this change,” he said. “I look forward to partnering with colleagues across the organisation to build a culture of excellence, innovation, collaboration and sustainable value for all stakeholders.” **LEADERSHIP CHANGE** Walsh will succeed Pieter Elbers, who resigned in March. He takes charge at a challenging time, with headwinds, including elevated operating costs, specifically jet fuel prices, airspace closures affecting routes and efficiency, and the need to rebuild passenger trust following recent disruptions. The appointment comes months after widespread

flight disruptions and cancellations that left thousands of passengers stranded and drew regulatory scrutiny. The airline was fined ₹22.20 crore, following an inquiry into the largescale disruptions, while several senior officials, including Elbers, received warnings over lapses in oversight and crisis management. The enforcement action followed an inquiry by a four-member committee constituted by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation after IndiGo reported 2,507 cancellations and 1,852 delays between December 3 and 5, 2025, affecting more than three lakh passengers. Following Elbers' exit, Managing Director and Co-founder Rahul Bhatia assumed interim management

until a new CEO was appointed. On the new appointment, IndiGo Chairman Vikram Singh Mehta said Walsh brings extensive experience in managing largescale airline operations and navigating complex market dynamics, adding that his leadership would support the airline's continued growth. Besides, Bhatia said the appointment comes as the airline enters a new phase of transformation, highlighting Walsh's global perspective and operational expertise. **EXPANSION PLANS** At present, IndiGo commands the highest market share in the domestic sector and is expanding internationally on the back of widebody aircraft acquisitions.

Unilever food arm to join McCormick in \$45 b deal

Bloomberg



Unilever agreed to combine its food business with spice maker McCormick in a \$44.8 billion deal that will create a global seasonings, sauces and condiments company. Under the agreement, McCormick will pay the Anglo-Dutch company \$15.7 billion and the equivalent of \$29.1 billion McCormick shares for most of Unilever's food business. That will leave Unilever and its shareholders with 65 per cent of the combined entity, including McCormick brands like French's mustard.

BIGGEST DEAL The deal is the biggest in the histories of both companies and will help recast Unilever as a global leader in beauty, personal and home care while turning McCormick into a bigger competitor in

the global packaged food business. The transaction will be carried out through a so-called Reverse Morris Trust, a type of merger that's designed to be tax-free. The transaction is a highly ambitious move by McCormick, which is best known for its red and white spice containers. McCormick is a much smaller company whose entire business only generates half the sales of Unilever's food arm.

5G subscriber base to exceed 1 billion by 2031: Nokia report

Our Bureau
New Delhi



India's 5G subscriber base could exceed one billion by 2031, said a report on Tuesday, adding that the country now has the world's second-largest 5G subscriber base and the second highest level of 5G data consumption, underlining the scale and maturity of its digital ecosystem. According to the findings of the 13th edition of Nokia's annual Mobile Broadband Index (MBIT), pan-India monthly 5G data traffic grew 70 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to reach 12.9 exabytes (EB) in 2025, contributing nearly 47 per cent of overall mobile broadband traffic. The telecom equipment maker's report noted that average monthly mobile data consumption per user also increased to over 31 gigabytes (GB) in 2025 as compared with 27.5 GB per user in 2024.

SURGING USAGE. The growth reflects the increasing demand for data-intensive use cases such as AI applications. The average data per user has recorded an 18.2 per cent compound annual growth rate (CAGR) over the past five years. **RAPID EXPANSION** This reflects the rapid expansion of enhanced mobile broadband (eMBB) and growing demand for data-intensive use cases, such as artificial intelligence (AI) applications, 4K video streaming and cloud gaming, the report noted. Overall data traffic crossed 27 EB per month in 2025 as compared 21.5 EB per month in 2024, reflecting sustained growth driven by expanding 5G coverage and the growing availability of affordable 5G smartphones, it said, adding that there was over 10X growth in budget (less than \$100/unit) 5G phone shipments in 2025 on a yearly basis. It said the number of active 4G devices reached 892 million in 2025, of which

Metros continue to lead adoption, with 5G now accounting for 58 per cent of total mobile data traffic in these markets

over 383 million are already 5G capable, while over 90 per cent of smartphones shipped during the year supported 5G, strengthening readiness for multi-band deployments in 5G. It mentioned that 137 million 5G smartphones were shipped (sold) in 2025. It further said metro circles continue to lead adoption, with 5G now accounting for 58 per cent of total mobile data traffic in these markets, up significantly from the previous year. Growth also accelerated across category A, B and C circles, indicating deeper nationwide penetration of 5G connectivity. The report also added that the existing

downlink-to-uplink traffic ratio is set to shift with the rise in uplink traffic, driven by the surge in AI-applications. The shift from traditional applications to real-time, immersive and autonomous systems will drive the need for AI-native networks designed to handle far more data, far more intelligence and far more complexity. **5G ADOPTION** “India's mobile broadband landscape is entering a new phase of evolution, driven by rapid 5G adoption and the growing influence of artificial intelligence (AI)-led applications. As networks transform to support new usage patterns and intelligent services, Nokia remains committed to partnering with telcos to build scalable, high-performance and future-ready connectivity infrastructure,” Vibha Mehra, Country Manager-Designate for India, Nokia, said.

Cosmoserve and Pixxel in deal to clear space debris

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Cosmoserve Space has partnered with Pixxel Space to leverage the latter's satellite technology platform for its upcoming mission to demonstrate space debris removal capabilities. The demonstration is likely to happen in early 2027. “With the number of defunct satellites increasing at an unprecedented pace, ensuring the long-term sustainability of Earth's orbital environment has become one of the most pressing challenges facing the global space industry,” Chiranjeevi Phanindra B, Founder and CEO at Cosmoserve Space, told *businessline*. “This partnership addresses that challenge by combining Pixxel's expertise in satellite engineering with our work in debris mitigation technologies,” he said.

CCTV curbs spark supply-chain overhaul, accelerating localisation

Sanjana B
Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

India's move to restrict non-certified CCTV cameras with foreign-linked components is triggering a structural reset in the surveillance ecosystem, pushing companies to rework supply chains and accelerate localisation efforts. Large manufacturers said that the transition away from Chinese-linked components has so far been manageable. Aditya Khemka, Managing Director of CP PLUS (Aditya Infotech Ltd), said the company had diversified its chip-set base and is working with partners such as Qualcomm, Ambarella and Realtek to meet regulatory requirements. “This transition has not slowed us down but has made us stronger. It has enabled us to build a resilient

and future-ready supply ecosystem,” Khemka said, adding that the company's IP portfolio is now built on 100 per cent non-Chinese chipsets. **SOURCE SHIFT** Across the industry, companies are increasingly shifting sourcing to suppliers in the US, Europe and Japan to reduce dependence on China. “We are diversifying our sourcing across Europe, the US and Japan, instead of relying on any one geography,” said Sparsh Sehgal, Chief Growth Officer at Sparsh CCTV. However, the shift is not translating into immediate localisation. “India does not have a system-on-chip (SoC) chip manufacturer today. Start-ups are working on it, but for real product use, the timeline is still three to five years,” Sehgal said.



IN NATIONAL INTEREST. Executives say the push is also being driven by growing concerns around data security **PI SIVAKUMAR**

“The supply chain has to move away from China, but it cannot move to India because that capability does not exist right now,” she added. **OPENING AVENUES** At the same time, the changes are beginning to create opportunities for Indian

semiconductor start-ups. Shashwath TR, Co-founder and CEO of Mindgrove Technologies, said the restrictions are driving demand for locally-designed silicon. “The policy creates a structural shift in the surveillance ecosystem. It accelerates demand for secure,

locally designed silicon,” he said. The company is working with Bosch to co-develop SoC solutions for applications including surveillance and smart infrastructure. Industry executives said the push is also being driven by growing concerns around data security. “This data, in the wrong hands, can expose a country's critical infrastructure, which is why the entire ecosystem — from chips to cloud — has to be trusted,” Sehgal said. **LOCALLY ALIGNED** Nikul Shah, Co-founder and CTO of IndiesemiC, said the move comes at a time when surveillance systems are becoming more connected and data-intensive. “CCTV systems today are no longer just recording devices; they are connected products that handle data, monitoring and access

across important environments,” he said. He added that the policy would push companies to focus more on compliance, quality and the source of technology, while also creating opportunities for Indian firms. In the near term, however, the transition is expected to come at a cost. Industry players estimate a 15-20 per cent increase in prices as companies move away from a concentrated supply chain and rebuild sourcing networks. While companies such as CP PLUS expect Indian chip capabilities to mature over the next two to three years, the current phase remains one of adjustment. For now, India's CCTV reset is not just about cutting dependence on China — it is also highlighting the work needed to build a deeper domestic electronics and semiconductor ecosystem.

RBI continues its trade relief measures amid W. Asia crisis

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Exporters will heave a sigh of relief as the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday said some of the November 2025 trade relief measures will continue due to ongoing geopolitical uncertainties and logistical disruptions. Exporters will continue to benefit from extension in the time period for realisation and repatriation of full export value of goods/software/services exported from nine months to 15 months from the date of export from India. **CRUCIAL FACILITY** Exporters may continue to avail the facility in accordance with the conditions stipulated therein, RBI said in a circular. Additionally, as part of the November 2025



trade relief measures, the period for realisation of both pre-shipment and post-shipment export credit was enhanced to 450 days for disbursements made till March 31, 2026. **EXPORT CREDIT** Given the continuing logistical disruptions due to the West Asia crisis, the RBI extended the enhanced export credit period of 450 days for all disbursements made till June 30, 2026.